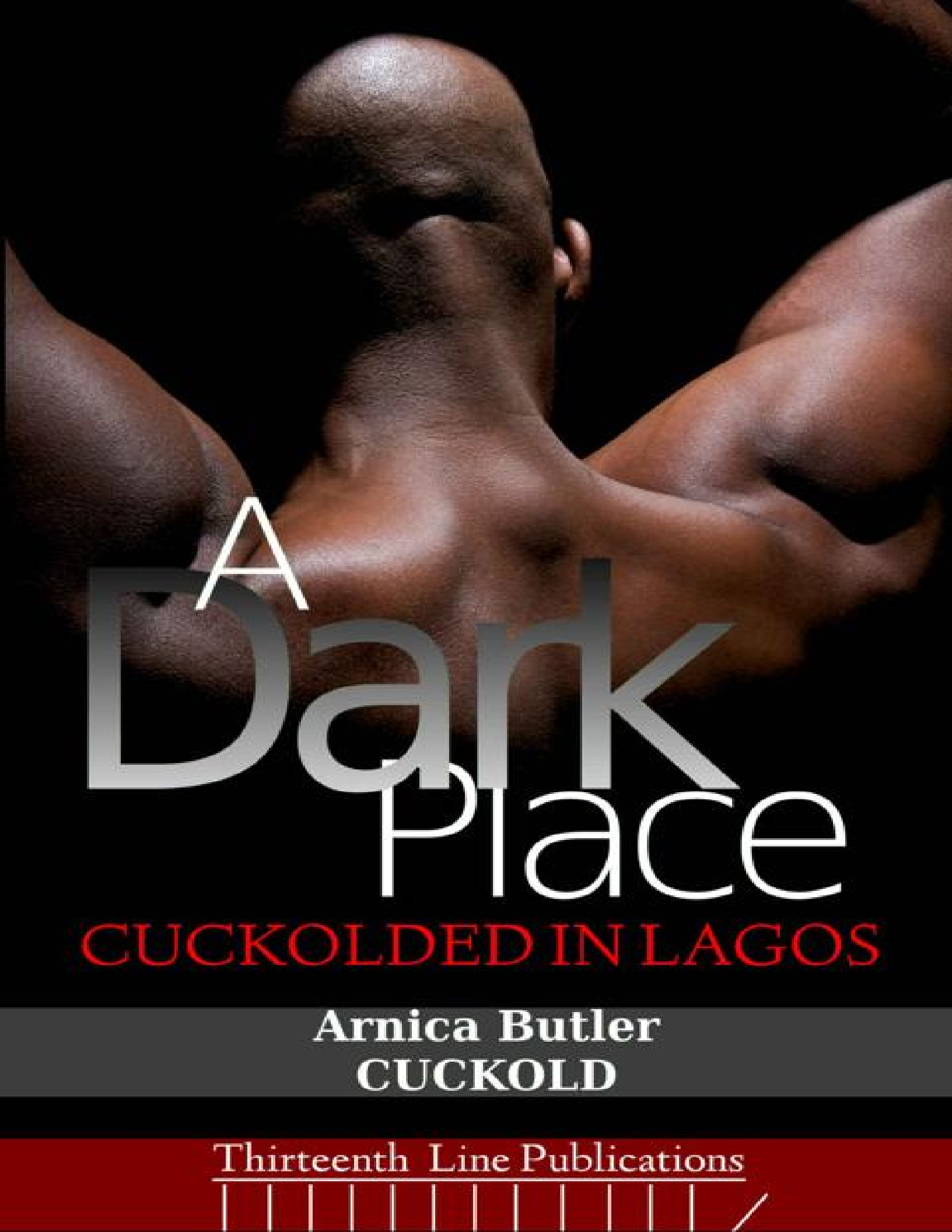




A Dark Place

CUCKOLDED IN LAGOS

Arnica Butler
CUCKOLD

Thirteenth Line Publications



A Dark Place

CUKOLDED IN LAGOS

By Arnica Butler

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Chapter 1: August

Andrew Walters reached a trembling hand up to his upper lip, where a thick sweat had formed and was beginning to tickle, like an insect crawling over his skin.

And it could be an insect, here in this jungled hell; even in the climate-controlled and meticulously cleaned rooms of his own house, the tropics could not be kept out. Even though his cock was wound up so tightly he thought it might break off, and he was close to bursting all over the towel he had brought with him into the dark confines of his own closet for just this occasion, the sweat had to be checked. Just in case. You never knew when a flesh-eating ant would find its way inside, despite the robust cleaning of their maid Oba.

The kind of ant that was unlike any you had ever seen.

The kind of big, fat tropical ant that would eat half your face off while you watched Clement Ambode ride your wife until she wet and unable to walk.

Clement was just getting going, but he had spent the better part of fifteen minutes slowly massaging Charlotte into the twisting, sweating mess she was now. He had begun slowly, covering her pale body with his muscled, black mass, and trailing his bright red tongue from her neck to her navel and back again while she moaned and whispered things Andrew couldn't hear.

He had pushed her legs open, firmly but with the delicacy of a flower arranger. He had placed them *just so*, knees slightly bent, one legs pushed up closer to her torso than the other. He had paused, a big, fit man, rippling in his own skin like steel beneath ink-black human skin, while he surveyed what he had before him. The curve of Charlotte's breasts, her pink nipples hard from him taking them in his mouth on his many journeys up and down her body. Her waist, the shadows where her thighs parted, the triangle of blond hair – hair that Charlotte now kept so neatly trimmed, so carefully groomed

-for *him*.-

And then, spreading open like a blooming flower, the pink lips of Charlotte's pussy, dripping like a morning flower covered in dew.

Andrew, tucked away in the closet, could see the bright, wet slit of her pussy. He could see how it was engorged, craving Clement's touch. Wetter, he thought miserably, than she ever was for him. Charlotte's hair was already sticking to her forehead, her skin already glistening with sweat, and Clement hadn't even started in on her yet.

He began teasing, placing a fingertip on her clit and passing over it with feathery touches that made her sigh and twist. Her hips moved up and down in desire.

Clement parted her petals one by one, feeling each layer of her between his fingers as though admiring silk. Andrew bit his own lip, imagining how soft and wet her flesh was to the touch. He watched Clement's face, the smug bastard. He was smiling, surely with the thought of how good it would feel when he stretched her open with his thick, black cock. Thinking about how it would feel as the head of his shaft passed between each of those swollen, soaked lips.

Surely, he was also thinking of how it was all sweetened by the fact that he was fucking another man's wife.

Clement toyed with Charlotte's clit, making circles on it with his forefinger. Charlotte, who was worked up into a lather, struggled to stay still enough for him to touch her. Her muscles contracted and twisted beneath her skin. Across the room and through the slatted closet door, Andrew could hear her ragged breathing, squeezed in her throat the way she would squeeze Clement's cock.

But still Andrew watched, aching with humiliation and pain, his cock robbing his body of circulation to the point he felt dizzy. His ears were ringing.

Clement dipped his finger into her hole, and brought it up to his mouth, tasting it like it was a sauce.

And then he went in again. Two fingers now, and they glided into her. Her thighs shone with her own juices. They were dripping down to the bed – into their bed, where Andrew would be able to smell them later.

Another dark, thick black finger joined the first two, and then another.

Andrew wanted to shut out the image as much as he wanted it to burn into his mind forever. Clement's enormous hand, a hand Andrew shook

frequently, was buried in his wife's tender flesh, pulling her apart. Dark as night against the stunning white of her skin.

Clement clawed upward with his hand inside of her – a move that Andrew had seen many times. Charlotte never ceased to be driven wild by this: she mewled and howled. She tossed her head back and forth on the pillows. Her legs were starting to tremble, but Clement held her still with his powerful gaze. This was not the first time he had fisted her, and she knew his rules. And she played by them. She played by them just as he wanted her to.

This was always the image that Andrew conjured first, when he was somewhere else in the middle of his day, and the thought that a big, black Nigerian was fucking his wife on a regular basis occurred to him. The image of Clement's fist buried in his wife's pussy, and Charlotte howling like a wild animal on the bed.

He pulled his fingers from her body, and his hand was coated in her juices. Andrew thought he could smell her from where he was, though perhaps it was just his fevered imagination. Her tangy-sweet pussy, her sweat, her desire.

Because it was desire, wasn't it? And he knew it was desire for Clement, for Clement's darkness. His size. The way he manhandled her with such ease, the way he took what he wanted and made her scream.

Now he leaned in and tugged at the skin above her clitoris. Her little button was hard, throbbing. The dark pink membrane that covered her raw flesh stretched away from his target: she writhed beneath him, eager to feel a tongue on her rawest part.

Since he had been watching Clement with his wife, Andrew had tried some of these things he did. It was Clement who knew where to touch his wife to make her scream, and Andrew had tried to follow his lead. Charlotte had panted for Andrew and put on a little show for him, but he knew he did something different. Something wrong. Whatever it was, he was not half as good as Clement, and everyone in the room, whether they knew who was there or not, at least knew this much.

Clement's large, purple lips parted and his red tongue appeared again to toy with her. He lapped at her clit with light touches that seemed to agonize her. The sounds Charlotte made were those of an animal, and they tortured Andrew's ears: she squeaked and growled, panted and whimpered. She was wrenching Oba's neatly folded sheets from under the mattress, and

Andrew watched them sliding up over the quilted mattress, wondering what Oba thought when she replaced them, wondering if Oba, too, knew what happened here in the afternoon.

Charlotte flopped around and screamed. She turned her head toward the closet, and bit her own lip until it was white. Andrew held his breath in his chest, hoping she would give him the treat that she sometimes did, of opening her eyes, looking over to where she knew he was hiding. Her eyes would burn through him then, while her black lover worked her into a frenzy and filled her up.

But today she kept her eyes closed. Her mouth open.

Andrew could see her orgasm rising up in her, her muscles were stiffening and her legs were trembling wildly, out of her control.

And then Clement, always driving her wild until she begged him, lifted his head.

An awful sound came from deep inside of Charlotte. A sheen of sweat covered her skin, her hair was damp and stuck to her forehead. She lifted her head.

Oh, here it was. Andrew's cock throbbed, hot and full. Here it came:

"Don't stop," Charlotte's voice was supplicant; truly, whoreishly, submissive. "Please. Don't stop." She was begging him now. She meant it, too, this begging she did for Clement. When she begged for Andrew it was an act, a thing he had asked her to do and a thing that she did to keep him happy. But when she begged for Clement it was because she was his plaything and he was hers. Because he satisfied her the way Andrew could not. Because she *wanted him* enough to actually beg.

"That's good," Clement's bass voice was a low rumble, his musical accent barely noticeable. "Beg me for more. What will you do for me, Charly, darling?"

Charlotte moaned.

She made all kinds of dirty, filthy promises, every one of them pulsing through Andrew's cock until it seemed as if it already had split open. She begged like a filthy whore wanting crack. When Clement's low voice issued his instructions to her, she flipped ever-so-willingly to her stomach, turning to face him.

Clement knelt, now, on a bizarre piece of furniture that Charlotte had insisted on buying. Not a footrest, not a bench. Too low and too small to really be anything believable. She had dismissed it as a luggage rack of

some kind. Now, as the reality of what it was, of its intended purpose all along, sank into Andrew's mind, his cheeks burned with the pain of it.

He watched Clement kneel, and saw it all happening as it was meant to happen. Had they actually measured things? It almost seemed as if they had. For Charlotte's mouth now so perfectly came to where his cock was, now that she was lying on her stomach, her heels in her hands (because Clement, as he always did, had requested that she leave on her shoes).

Andrew watched as Clement took his cock and flicked it on his wife's obediently extended tongue.

He moved forward just an inch, and the very tip of his black cock touched Charlotte's lips. They closed around the tip of him, and she sucked on him like a lollipop, as though she wanted to suck his orgasm from him. She took breaks only to breathe, before she went after him again.

He let her lick and suck away for several minutes, while he growled his praise for her efforts. Andrew watched his eager wife, lifting her head, holding her heels.

"That's it, good girl." His black hand moved to her hair, and cradled the back of her head like an American football.

Andrew's cock was so hard it was sending pain through his entire lower body, and the hand on his wife's head – the knowledge of what would come next – ripped through him like a knife.

He started to feel sick from the pain as Clement worked his fingers into her hair. As though she were a blow-up doll, his once-pristine wife Charlotte opened her mouth nice and wide, with no command at all, and let him slide her face all the way down his shaft.

Andrew watched, his eyes upon the black meat where it met her stretched lips, as she took the whole thing in her mouth. As it moved down her throat, filling up her neck, where it moved through her skin like an animal inside a snake.

He wanted to close his ears the way he closed his eyes as she started to make her moaning noises, as she made sounds that were distorted by all the cock in her mouth but sounded like what she would say to a great meal.

Clement tightened his grip on her hair and held her still.

Andrew watched, horrified even though he knew it was coming, because he had seen it so many times before, as Clement began to face-fuck his wife.

He watched every detail. The long threads of saliva in silver threads, from her lips to the tip of his cock. The puffing of her cheeks, the bulge that moved in her throat.

From deep in her throat came the sounds of her absolute submission. Choking, sticky gurgling. And her sultry, moaning approval. She was eating up all of his fat purple cock with such enthusiasm, as though it tasted like the sweet dark chocolate it was the color of.

Clement pulled his cock from her mouth and stood heaving over her. As if he was deciding what to do. But they all knew what he would do now: he was going to fuck the shit out of Andrew's wife. He was going to have that enormous black cock inside of every hole, and she was going to squeal and take it, and then Clement Ambode was going to watch his cum splatter all over her face, or watch it ooze from her raw, pounded ass, or fill up her pussy.

If he was lucky, Charlotte would treat Andrew to his favorite view. The one where he could see the dark cock that pummeled her, as it disappeared into her flesh, but Charlotte could also easily turn to look at him. She would look at him and grind his shame into him, the way Clement ground his seed into her.

Andrew always wondered if perhaps Charlotte betrayed this secret: if perhaps as Clement pressed his thumbs into her gaping asshole and watched his creamy froth spill out of her ass, he knew that Andrew was watching it, too.

But there were so many secrets in this room. Some had been kept, and some had not.

And Clement Ambode was a strictly confidential professional. When Andrew met him in public, Ambode only looked at him with the same unhurried expression he had first bathed over him. It revealed nothing.

Andrew closed his eyes.

How did he get here? How did everything go so wrong and so right in the wet, dark heart of Africa?

Chapter 2: April

“You know,” Charlotte said, and Andrew had half a mind to take cover before she flung something sharp at him. He could tell just by the tone of those two words that he had misspoken.

Oh, to take it back.

He was replaying everything that had transpired between them in the last five minutes, searching for what had prompted Charlotte to fume silently, and then begin what was sure to be a tirade.

“It's more than just a *hobby*.”

Oh, that.

“It's not a fucking *hobby*. If you *remember*, which you rarely do, you might *recall* that I was getting *paid* for my work, that I *won awards* for my work, that I am considered to be a *fucking professional*, and you would do well to keep your mouth shut if you cannot find *anything* to come out of it except *rubbish*, which we have plenty of it as it, thank you very much!” Charlotte waved her hand, which was now holding a knife, in the direction of the heaped garbage on the street that had not been collected for two weeks. Reasons unknown.

Andrew took a deep breath. Charlotte angry meant Charlotte's washed-away British accent resurfaced, and Andrew liked it very, very much.

Rubbish.

“Do *not*!” Charlotte screamed, waving the knife in his direction now, “Begin that idiotic smirking of yours because you think, and I quote, 'it is very *hot*' when I use words like rubbish. This is a serious conversation and the only rubbish around here is the rubbish you're talking!”

She looked at him, and he wanted desperately to remove the expression on his face from his face, but it was too late, and Charlotte had flown off the handle. This was the American side of her, and there was no retreat. He kept a wary eye on the knife, which was very sharp and being used to punctuate her sentences now.

“Do you think I'm having a laugh? Is that what you think? This is serious. The only reason I am even in this god-forsaken, rat-infested, shithole of a shitfuck dump is because of you, and your career, and your bloody business – wipe that fucking smile off your fucking face you sod! - and I will be damned if I will wrap myself up in Dolce and Gabbana space-age crap fashion and sit around with a bloody teacup in my hand while you wankers wank each other off and I smile demurely and mind my own corporate business...”

Such a jumble of pan-Atlantic swear words. Andrew stifled a smile.

She turned back to the vegetables she had been chopping, and was now macheting, talking to herself. “Oh, thank you very *much*, Alana, you also look *very* bulimic and your botox *does* become you, you simply *must* give me your doctor's name....you like it, Ashley? It's White Dwarf platinum, yes, and it actually feels that hot on your scalp but the scarring eventually goes away...”

She fell silent, and only the clatter of the cutting board as she slammed the knife into it could be heard.

Andrew stayed silent. Oh, if he could only take back the word *hobby*. What would have worked? Something to do? A vocation? A distraction?

I'm so happy you've found something to fill your time...

When she next spoke, her accent had gone neutral again, a soft and unique blend of her haughty English and the American drawl she would never completely perfect, something which often led to her being mistaken for an Australian:

“I am a professional journalist,” she said calmly, “and I am doing a job. So kindly refrain from condescending me. And do not even *think* about trying to talk me out of it.”

Andrew reflected that he rarely dreamed about talking her out of anything. It had not even occurred to him to talk her out of this. He hadn't had time; she had started yelling at him before he could say much else.

Now that he thought about, though, it did seem like he should try to talk her out of wandering around Lagos unaccompanied, doing research on...

Andrew scanned his mind for what she had been telling him about the story, but as usual, he was unable to recall it.

His mind had been elsewhere: on any one of the sixty or so balls he had up in the air, any one of which could fall to the ground and break into a

million shattered pieces. All of them worth millions, some of them conceivably worth billions. All of them dangerous, all of them volatile. Especially here, where doing business in the most legal of ways was barely legal.

His career was clinging to each one of these juggling balls like a paper-thin piece of glass.

“I just wanted to say...I think it's good you found something to...keep you busy here.”

It was the wrong thing.

She was shaking her head now, chopping furiously. Mumbling.

“You just wanted to say something that wouldn't make it obvious you weren't listening, as you never are. But thank you. Thank you *so much* for your approval.”

The cool sickness that he often got when she talked to him like this, so disappointed, so disdainful, seized Andrew. But she didn't quiz him on what he had failed to hear, and so he was off the hook, finished with his coffee, and it was time for him to leave. He looked at his watch as though it were his savior. His driver would be here soon.

Just as quickly as Charlotte had flared up, his own mind flared up, on to something else.

Chapter 3: All For Charlotte

It was essential, and it was expected, to have a driver in Lagos. Which was fine with Andrew, who felt ill at ease maneuvering through the potholes, the people, and the other drivers of Lagos – not to mention the livestock – who all moved in a reckless dance common to any developing country. *People, it all said, die here all the time. You could be next.* The difference of course being that the inhabitants of Lagos didn't care about it the same way Andrew did. They shrugged it off, like they shrugged off the heat, the power outages, the threat of malaria, the radical Muslims, the roulette of dictatorships and democracies.

How liberating, and how terrifying, to be like that.

He was bitter from his discussion with Charlotte, the way he was bitter nearly every time he spent more than five minutes in the room with his wife. Charlotte didn't understand, and there seemed to be no way to make her understand. *All of this was for her.* All the cocktail parties, the dubious dealings, moving here to the goddam rat-infested heart of darkness. The hours he bled into contracts and papers, contracts and papers...it was all for Charlotte.

He had thought that just coming to Nigeria had invigorated her somehow, and the slow drying-up she had been experiencing over the past ten years would bloom in the tropical heat.

Nigeria had invigorated him. Like a horror film, but still. Maybe that had been what he had mistaken in Charlotte.

There was the good: He was finally going somewhere in Sidel Group. He was not a lackey any longer; he was the man who presented the plans, the man who designed the elaborate mechanisms by which capital would flow through the blossoming heart of Nigeria, seen where it should be seen, unseen where it should not be. Nigeria was where it was at, and Andrew Walters had come here with the first of the venture investors and not the last. He was finally going to be the kind of name that people said with deference.

Andrew Walters, of Sidel? He was in Nigeria before it was Nigeria.

After Nigeria became whatever Nigeria was going to be, and Andrew had made a part of just that, it would all be relaxing drinks and cigar smoke. It would be him making someone else run around in the jungle, or the cold frozen tundra, or wherever the hell Sidel went to next, chasing the ever-elusive flow of liquid gold capital.

And why?

It was not because Andrew Walters of Sidel was the kind of man who *wanted* to be in Nigeria before it was Nigeria. Nigeria fucking terrified him. There were the insects, to begin with. The flesh-eating diseases lurking in the ocean, the dark expanse of weird, jungly savannah that menaced at the outer edges of the city.

And then there were the cold, hard stares of the dark people who inhabited this reptilian city.

Well. The women's stares were less terrifying, to be sure, and he let his gaze fall on the high, tight ass of a woman in the street to underline his own point to himself.

But the rest of Nigeria was fucking sweating, black, knife-filled nightmare.

It was all for Charlotte. Charlotte full and round with wet eyes, who he loved and wanted to keep. Charlotte who had patiently waited, all this time, for him to make something of himself. Charlotte who wanted to be a mother and whose disappointment lurked on her face all the time.

Charlotte whose dissatisfaction with everything he had failed to give her was seeping slowly into her and turning her love into a poison.

Andrew watched the city pulsing outside the window. Lagos was almost always the same temperature, day and night, like the best of summer days. For a moment he felt like putting the window down, and his mind went back in time, to New York. To leaving in a car with the windows down and the summer heat flushing Charlotte's cheeks, her legs stretched out to the dashboard, her hair gently lifting in the breeze.

That was a long time ago.

Now, he didn't dare put the window down. And Charlotte never put her legs on the dashboard.

These things were too dangerous.

The car made its way onto the Third Mainland Bridge. The Lagoon yawned to his right, and the city began to disintegrate. He was leaving the manicured Lagos for the real Lagos, because that's where the Nnaji brothers

wanted to meet. Never on the island, the fucking bastards. Always where the beat of Lagos' Nigerian heart could be heard. Terrifying. Methodical. Slow. Like the heartbeat of a panther, lying in wait.

Andrew felt the cool discomfort he was becoming so used to in Nigeria spread through his chest. It was like heartburn. He felt it all the time.

He took a Tums for it, and tried to remember why he was here.

All for Charlotte.

Every man in Nigeria seemed to have been hewn from the same dark, hardened stone. They were all solid muscle, all bursting from their own skins. Every man in Nigeria seemed to be a foot taller than him, and enormous in every way. They all seemed to have thick chests, muscled arms, giant manly jaws, hands that wrapped around his and made him somehow look like a child's doll. Their laughs were large, their voices boomed. And every pair of dark brown eyes seemed to shrink Andrew further, to a small and nervous man.

They had the hardened expressions that all men in the major cities in Africa wore. This was a serious fucking place, where only the strong survived, and for real African men there was no escape from it, no driving out of it. There was no leaving on corporate jets like their European and American partners, when military juntas came through town with machetes, or some terrible fatal disease came to swallow them all alive in a feverish hell.

This was a country where all men were really men: you got things in Lagos by being smarter, being meaner, and being bigger than anyone else. Not just by finishing law school, like Andrew. No, in Nigeria you had to finish law school, but you had to be able to be in a knife fight, too. And come out alive.

These were the kind of men who stood impassively and watched men with machetes come running.

Andrew was the kind of man who ran away screaming like a woman.

Andrew knew that the intimidation he felt as he walked through the streets of Lagos, or into one of his business meeting, would never fade. He felt their stares on him like a film. He felt his own weakness acutely.

Andrew often felt, in every meeting like this one, outside of the safe confines of Sidel's downtown building, that he was going to be eaten alive

as soon as his function had been served.

Actually eaten alive. The expressions on these dark faces lent themselves easily to an image of one of them ripping your flesh off the bone while smiling.

He reminded himself that he was a lawyer, and a skilled writer of contracts. Ethically questionable, but artistically law-warping and sound contracts that contorted money and wrapped it up safely for the keeping – and these men had a lot of money that wasn't easy to cage. Andrew was not much of a man, physically, when standing next to these men, but his sharp mind found every loophole the law birthed, and this is what kept the men who used the services of Sidel Group from squashing him like an insect.

He was so deep in thought that the car stopped long before he expected it, and he looked up at the cement building with a sense of dread. The driver made a very low noise of impatience. It was already too late: the throngs of people in the streets had already absorbed them. The hostile faces glared at the windows. Andrew knew they saw only their own reflections, but he always felt as though he were exposed here. He felt like they glared directly at him.

But they backed away, because drivers of cars like Andrew's were armed, and men like Andrew would likely be missed by someone even more armed.

He took a deep breath, snatched up his briefcase, and pushed the door open gently. The great masses of people moved away from it, and passed him with a cool stare. This time, it was definitely for him.

The Havannah Club (a clever but likely accidental mixture of *savannah* and *Havana*) smelled like Havana must have in 1951: the entire restaurant was hazy with sweet Cuban cigar smoke, and expensive Scotch evaporated into the air out of snifters on deep mahogany tables. There was no way to know what it was from the outside: its dingy facade barely advertised its existence, and only a small sign, printed on a piece of scrap wood, even gave it a name. Andrew often wondered how the ultra-rich interior had arrived here in one piece.

Probably like he had, under a vague threat. Like everything in Lagos.

When Andrew entered the room, the darkness broke open for a moment with blinding white smiles. The wolves bared their teeth, and then their black faces returned to their somber expressions.

“What have you got for us today?”

Andrew had contracts. He always had contracts, and he always had places for money to go. Sidel Group moved money from one place to another, made sure it was taxed as little as possible and scrutinized even less, and all of that involved a lot of paperwork to be signed under the steely stares of these men.

Andrew set his briefcase down and tried not act jittery. Something about the cold demeanor of his Nigerian clients – a calm that belied their ruthlessness in business (and he could imagine, anything else) made him feel like a towel-boy in a locker room. It filled him with the same dread he had felt in high school as he approached his locker, wedged between the lockers of two animal-like football players, who had enjoyed staring him down and denying him access on a whim.

The fear he felt, for some reason, twisted inside of him remarkably close to his crotch.

He preferred not to give that a great deal of thought.

“Gentlemen,” he said, and he tried to sound confident, but he felt like a fool. They looked at him, he felt, like he *was* a fool. But a necessary fool. And an expensive one. “I’ve got a number of things for you to sign.”

Chapter 4: Reliability

Andrew watched the street moving below, the endless shifting of cars and people. Dark heads, bobbing as they made their way through the impenetrable streets of Lagos.

“Mate,” Theo said, trying to break through to him. “This is a bad country. This is a *bad* country where *bad* things happen all the time. You've got to do *something*.”

Andrew turned his gaze back into the office.

He had confided in Theo, though he couldn't say why, about Charlotte's plans to do vague research on the streets of Lagos – and not the island, Lagos, but *Lagos-Lagos*. The same sweaty dump from which he had just returned, armpits wet with heat and fear.

Andrew typically didn't have much time to think deeply about anything from his personal life during the day, but when he did, he thought of Charlotte. Her plans troubled him, and his troubles hung around him like smog. He imagined her walking the streets alone, hundreds of dark eyes on her, hundreds of dangers lurking in every humid, dirty corner of the city.

Theo had leaned back with his hands clasped behind his head and opened his mouth in his typical expression of disbelief, which had immediately made Andrew regret telling him anything personal. Andrew already knew that everyone at Sidel talked about him in whispers: He couldn't control his wife. His wife did whatever she wanted, and Andrew let her – not because he didn't care, but because he couldn't do anything about her.

But then Theo had, to Andrew's surprise, become very helpful.

Theo placed a business card on the desk. It was an expensive job, slightly shiny. Not the typical deskjet-printed business card from fly-by-night Lagos, and there was plenty of that. Half of Lagos went up in the morning and down by midnight before it could be found by anyone ever again. The next day, all the same people were in place, but the businesses

were new, and no one knew what you were talking about if you flashed one of those cards around, asking where the business had gone.

The card read, only:

Clement Ambode

Strictly Confidential

Andrew fingered the mysterious card, wondering how much “strictly confidential” business such a vague description covered, but knowing Lagos, it was probably quite a bit.

“How do you know this guy?” Andrew said, turning the card over as though for a clue.

“Everyone knows him. He's done something for everyone here. A man like Clement is indispensable in a country like this.”

Andrew looked at the card. “So he's a...” he lowered his jaw, hoping that Theo would finish his sentence, but Theo only smiled.

“He's whatever you want him to be, mate. But he's reliable.”

Reliable, in Lagos, meant he was part of the permanent and underground infrastructure of things; the greasing of wheels, the greasing of palms, the lubrication of the systematic corruption that made the whole city, and the whole country, work in its own mysterious ways.

“And expensive, I assume.”

Theo put his hands on the back of his head and kicked his feet up on Andrew's desk. Andrew stamped down on the urge to hit his feet and send him spilling onto the floor. The guy was a really pompous ass, at the end of the day.

The fading sunlight turned his pale skin a healthy orange, as though he had been on vacation. “This place,” he said cryptically, “is one of the last places on earth where you get what you pay for, and you pay for what you get...”

He began a Gordon Gekko-esque speech, praising capitalism in all of its brutality in Africa's pulsing heart. Andrew tuned him out. He'd heard it all before, and he'd been settling his own moral accounts with creative bookkeeping for a long time. He told himself all kinds of things to make their business dealings in Nigeria seem more legitimate, but unlike Theo, Andrew never bought his own story. What Theo's speech boiled down to, anyway, was that Clement Ambode, title unknown, was expensive. Whatever it was that he did.

Andrew placed the card in his pocket.

He would feel like too much of a shit, spying on Charlotte in this dark way.

Wouldn't he?

But wasn't this how things were done here?

In the dark. Always darkly, where no one knew exactly what the other was doing.

He looked at his watch.

"We've got cocktails."

It would all have to wait.

In America, Charlotte was not the first woman that men looked at.

But that's probably because in America, Charlotte was always in a room full of tightly wound attorneys and high-powered businessmen, and they were all white, and they all had scrawny twenty-year-olds clinging vacantly to them, instead of their actual wives. Or in rare cases, those same wives, who were also scrawny and had shrunk their faces to their bones with enough botox to paralyze an elephant.

Charlotte was a size ten, and she was five foot ten, and her thighs certainly did not curve inward. Her curves were perfectly proportioned, though, and she was tightly condensed by years of toning exercise. She ran, and she did hours of daily pilates.

When she put on a tight dress, such as the one she was wearing today, her well-proportioned curves attracted the eyes of everyone. In America, men watched her with their peripheral vision, confused by their attraction to a larger woman than the corporate norm.

In Lagos, they watched her like she was the only thing in the room. Men stopped talking to watch her, and they seemed utterly unconflicted by their attraction to her.

She was big. She was blond. And they were stripping her from the moment she walked in the room. Peeling her red dress right off of her.

It seemed to Andrew that Charlotte had become less and less oblivious about this, even though she outwardly claimed to be. It seemed to him that she moved her hips differently, that she met more eyes, that she winked without winking, that she was letting her necklines plunge deeper and her skirts rise higher.

Not so high that she looked terribly out of place among the handful of Sidel Group wives who had braved life in Lagos. She joined them where

they were clustered by the bar, her plastic smile ratcheted up to its most poisonous variety.

The wives had changed since they arrived here, but they couldn't achieve what Charlotte had no matter how much they worked out on the butt machine at the gym. They looked wan and stringy, and Charlotte looked vibrant and full. And in Lagos, it was vibrant and full that was prized. It was Charlotte who drew the attention of men here. She was impossible to look away from.

Andrew thought about the strangeness of it, how the change in the male energy had changed the way Charlotte appeared even to him. What portion of this "change" was not change at all, and rather just what Andrew could see more clearly in her, now that other men saw it too?

He was frowning, so he brought his glass to his lips and managed a smile.

She was holding her glass of red wine the same way she might have held at home; she was standing next to the same women...but Charlotte, who had seemed to fade into the background before, was now the one who drew Andrew's eye.

He looked around the room.

There was a table full of black men in their thirties, heads together, eyes moving over Charlotte's ass from across the room. Andrew held up his wine glass, as though to see something on it but really to look through it: when these men caught his eye he felt squeezed in the balls. Especially when he caught them looking at his wife. They never blinked first, and they never backed down. They just kept staring at him until he lost some genetic battle, written into him before his birth, and looked away. He was not an alpha male.

You are, their stares always said, just before he looked away, *a fucking sap. A white-bread small little man, and I've already snapped you in two.*

What could they be saying, he wondered. What was the exchange, between men like that, as they looked at his wife? What filthy thing had been said that ended in their low laughter, their eyes still on her body?

Andrew placed his hand in his pocket and fingered the card.

No. He would feel like a shit.

Theo appeared behind him then. He had an uncanny ability materialize, always, at the right time and place. Reading people's minds.

Whispering in their ears. It made him successful at business. It was his specialty.

“Just give a call, mate,” he said. 'Mate' was lost to the jumble of peanuts in his mouth.

He's whatever you want him to be.

An idea began to form in Andrew Walters' mind.

Chapter 5: Clement Ambode

Andrew regretted everything immediately, but as he pressed the red icon on his phone, he knew it was too late to do anything about it.

Clement Ambode's low voice had explained patiently that he did not discuss things over the phone. He would meet him at Odalia Cafe.

Andrew would know him because he was the tall black man.

Just a hint of a laugh when he said this, and it wasn't until after he hung the phone up that Andrew understood the joke.

To understand Clement Ambode, you had to know something about Lagos. There was that anyone could rise up from the slums, and into the glassy cafes on Victoria Island. Anyone could end up here, dressed, as he was, in a charcoal-colored suit with a black tie that cost more than his family had made in his entire childhood.

But you had to be a certain kind of man if you were going to do that.

Clement Ambode never spoke of these things. And now his father and mother were dead, and his brothers had left for the capital. They were not mean enough to make money in Lagos, and mean is what is what you had to be. Somewhere inside, you had to have a hardness about you.

Clement was also confidential. He had learned that there were a lot of things that needed to be done for these investors, things they didn't want to do themselves, and things they didn't really want to admit to having anything to do with.

He liked that black Americans called them Crackers.

You had to smile at their arrogance, take their money, and then place a little piece of cheese on them to eat with your wine.

But it was a minor inconvenience. In the end – and the end was all that mattered - Clement Ambode had a penthouse in the new high rises that looked out into the ocean. And that was a long way from a shack behind a polluted lumber yard.

So Clement smoothed his tie as he watched the newest of his many clients from Sidel Group wriggle around in Odalia Cafe. Eyes shifting, angular face moving ten directions at once. It perplexed Clement constantly

that the pasty-skinned Europeans, with their stringy, fretting wives, had managed to do anything at all this world, let alone take most of it over.

He met the man's eyes, let him wonder for a few beats, and then nodded his head slowly.

Clement was not a man of quick, unthinking motions.

"Mr. Ambode?"

Oh Jesus help him, a fucking Yank.

Clement smoothed his tie again. Nodded again. Extended one enormous hand outward, palm up, to indicate that Andrew Walter, Another American Cracker, should sit down.

Clement could have guessed, before he let Andrew simmer, that the man's problems were with his wife.

He had the energy of man who is nervous about his wife.

A lot of men got nervous about their wives in Lagos.

"Mr. Walters. Can I order you something to drink or eat?"

Clement was a master of linguistic imitation, which was a necessity in his job, and his English for meetings of this kind was of the high-class Nigerian kind, still African but slightly British. It was not his natural dialect but he made it seem as though it were. It said to his clients that he was Like Them, and yet Nigerian Enough, a smart black man who could move between their world and his own.

Even Americans, with their persistent claims to not be racist, and god, anything but classist, ate it up.

Walters sat nervously and then dove in, after running a hand through his hair. The humidity of Lagos had the comical effect of making every white person look frazzled.

Clement's own hair was neatly shaved to the skin.

"It's...I...I guess I'm not sure if you do this kind of thing," Andrew said. And then he looked hopelessly at him.

"I do all manner of things, Mr. Walters. Tell me what it is and if I cannot do it I will refer you to someone who will." His voice plodded through the humid air like a tank.

Walters' eyes shifted from side to side again.

Clement hoped the man did not want to kill his wife. That was something he did not do.

"It's a little unethical, so I feel bad but...my wife is a journalist, you see. And so...I don't want her...Lagos is a dangerous city. But she won't

listen to me, she wants to be independent...”

The man blathered on and on. Clement had the story sized up in a few moments, but he turned on his most sympathetic face and listened, his deep brown eyes focused as though Walters were telling him the secrets to the universe.

He let Walters run on and on, until he wore himself out. It often seemed like a man had done all of the talking he was going to do, but there were always the last little splatters, when he revealed the most about himself, as all men do, in the final sentences of any speech like this one.

He repeated how dangerous Lagos was.

He repeated that she was a woman traveling alone.

He did not say, *and she is white, and this country is full of men like you.*

There was no need to explain that bit.

He fell silent.

Clement took out a handkerchief and wiped the table before him before leaning on it to speak. He placed his two enormous black hands together and formed a formidable double fist, which he pointed in Walters' direction.

Andrew flinched a little.

“I gather then, Mr.. Walters, that you do not want your wife to know that I am investigating her.”

“No. I mean, yes...no, yes...that's what I want, is for her to not know that.”

“May I suggest then, that I arrange to offer my services as a fixer?”

Walters fell silent.

“And then...you would...here's the thing,” he stuttered. “I don't want you to actually...interfere with anything she might be...doing.”

Clement kept his smile away from his face.

Ah yes.

He had seen it all before. Usually Brits, but just as often, now, Americans.

Men who deep down inside *wanted* to find their wives fucking another man.

Men who wanted their wives fucked by a real man.

Clement had been around long enough to see it in their eyes.

He moved over the surface of Walters' pale eyes and wondered if he was the type who had admitted it to himself.

“Mr. Walters,” he said slowly. “I will do exactly what you employ me to do. Nothing more, and nothing less. I am sure that Mr. Theodore Hinton has advised you of my reliability.”

Walters exhaled.

There was that word again. *Reliability*.

“How would you go about...how would you arrange it so that...” He floundered. He was flapping around like a fish dying on the beach.

It was unlike him to be inarticulate. Unlike him, a vendor of words, to be unable to say what he wanted.

Clement's face changed in no way, and he waited for Walters to become silent again.

“I have my ways,” Ambode said, finally. “What I will need is just a bit of information from you. And of course a...” he waved his hand in the air, as though looking for the right word. “Retainer.”

Chapter 6: The Fixer

Charlotte gave herself a final glance in the full-length mirror. There was no true blending in here in Nigeria: she was pale and she was blond. But there were ways of making herself look like she had not just arrived, another wife dragged to the confines of Victoria Island, who spent her days shopping in upscale stores and relaxing afterward in upscale spas.

When Sidel Group had decided to move Andrew to Nigeria, she had been filled with a sense of excitement. They had been living in Chicago for years, and it had felt like the cement was settling in around her feet. When she had met Andrew, he had been taking his career in the direction of human rights law, she was a journalist. They were idealists.

Somehow he had ended up at Sidel, and at the time it had seemed like an opportunity.

Well, at the time it had seemed like a godsend: between the two of them they had been scraping together \$50,000 in New York City and living off of dwindling credit.

Andrew began in a position with a nebulous title, a “cultural affairs consultant.” They would spring from that to the kind of well-funded philanthropy they had always wanted to do. Or change the bad world from the inside.

At the time, Charlotte had known in the back of her mind that they would end up as they were now, but she had allowed herself to buy into the corporate mission statements, the cryptic wording of his job description, and she had turned a blind eye as his job disintegrated into a standard legal consultant job for a large financial company.

She had turned a blind eye because it was seductive. It was seductive to fly in a company jet, to vacation in Tahiti, to have a large, open-concept apartment on the top floor of a lakeshore building, looking out over blue waters.

But it had come with a sacrifice. The interests of Sidel Group did not allow her to write the things she really wanted to write. Sidel Group did not need to be associated, in any way, with any critical articles about low-

income workers in exploited corners of the world, or any of the bad things that happened in dark corners and behind closed doors.

Because at the end of the day, Sidel Group had probably closed one of those doors, or sent a representative to be there behind it, or transferred the money that built the door.

It had been conveyed to her as though by osmosis, over the years, through Andrew, and through the wives. Sidel Group had an image to protect, and this extended to everyone in the Sidel family. *It would be troublesome, Charlotte, if someone could not be promoted because of conflicting interests.*

Etc., etc.

It hadn't happened overnight. None of it had. Charlotte loved Andrew, and she wanted him to succeed. The material wealth helped ease it all along. It was like sugar in tea, she started to have a taste for it. More of it, never less of it.

She had decided she could write something else.

She had decided to try and have a baby.

She had decided this and decided that, and now here they were, very clearly on the wrong-ish side of their original values.

She had seen in her own investigations: no one ever woke up and saw where the line was and decided to cross it. Everyone just inched this way or the other in a fog, and then one day they turned around and found themselves in much different place than they ever thought they would be, and there was no way back.

There was no way, she had realized, to unravel everything. To go back to her career without leaving Andrew, to ask him to throw everything he had worked so hard for away, to get back to when they had first met and lived in a ratty Brooklyn apartment with a bathtub in the kitchen.

And even if there were, she didn't like admitting it to herself, but she didn't want to throw everything away.

Not really.

Nigeria had seemed like a chance to start a new chapter. She didn't have to write hard-hitting investigative pieces, like her last book, an exploration of mid-level South American officers who had taken part in atrocities and were now old grandfathers and a story to tell. She could write fiction, or a travelogue, or a dreamy memoir. But she had to do *something*.

She had settled on beige pants, fitted and tight on her round buttocks, flaring at the bottom. Nigerian women wore colors, and they were incredibly beautiful in them, but Charlotte knew she looked silly imitating a vibrancy she didn't have. The pants were expensive, because she didn't want to look like a tourist in fucking khakis. Her blouse was cream-colored and plunged between her breasts. Her eyes rested on the attractive shape of each breast, neatly outlined by the tight-fitting blouse. A wide black belt joined the two.

She had spent hours choosing it, the right blend of not-tourist, of foreignness and nativeness, of wealth that would make her important enough to speak to but not so distant that no one would speak to her. She was not Nigerian, and she could never hide that. The impression she wanted to give was one of understanding Nigeria.

There was a feeling of hope in Lagos, a palpable feeling. It was the feeling that out of the darkness on this continent a real city would emerge, one that would put Africa on the map. A city that flights would connect to, a city that people would visit. And everyone here would do anything to make it happen.

Anything at all.

Charlotte knew, in the back of her mind, that there was more to the story than that. But it seemed like something she could write about without pissing off Sidel. Sidel, after all, publicly sold themselves as having a hand in this venture. Sidel was here to help make it happen.

Charlotte twisted a bright red stick of lipstick, considered it for a moment, and then pressed it against her lips. She expected the effect to be whoreish, but it somehow worked with her subdued tones. Her lips were full, and one of her best features. She puckered them for the mirror, and gave herself another satisfied look in the mirror.

Anything at all. That's what people would do here. She felt desire crawling underneath her skin.

She dismissed the thought quickly. It bothered her how she felt. How something snuck up on her in the night here. Like the humidity, like the heat...never sudden. Always probing inside of her, slowly.

She shook her head and focused on her clothing.

It was nice to be in a country where men appreciated a full figure.

Something in her abdomen, low down, close to her pelvis, shifted slightly and spread out, almost cold, inside of her, as she thought of all the

intense, clean-shaven, hard Nigerian men who watched her every move. Their eyes hid nothing about what they wanted.

Charlotte blinked.

Good Christ, get a hold of yourself, Charlotte.

But her mind had a way of refusing to stop thinking what it wanted, even if she tried to concentrate on something else, and so when she stepped out into the wall of humid heat on the ostentatious steps leading up to their townhome, it was still on her mind. They were still on her mind. And the white-hot feeling was uncoiling already.

That's when she saw Clement Ambode.

He seemed to rise forever from behind the car, stepping out of the driver's seat and into the hot air. Foot after foot of hard, black man, rising until he reached his full height of six-foot-seven. One hand moved to button his jacket, a shimmering and expensive material that was not an ordinary driver's garb. He moved slowly, without any difference, just a calm and professional demeanor.

Charlotte felt weak. She actually felt weak in the knees.

His voice, low and lyrical, seemed to stroke her rather than resonate in her ears.

"Ms. Walters. I'm Clement Ambode."

He extended his hand, which seemed to be that of a giant. When it closed around hers, it absorbed it in its heat, and her own hand completely disappeared.

Charlotte's mind went very much where it shouldn't. She watched his lips as he explained that he was her fixer, but he was also her driver, that he could get her access to almost anything she needed, that he had read the outline of her research plans, that he needed to return today by 10pm but was otherwise clear for all hours of the day, every day, at her service.

But he did not have the simpering tone of a man who provided customer service. The words, *all hours of the day, every day, at your service* curled up inside of her and vibrated like a sleeping cat.

It was almost as if he was telling her what he *would* do with her.

To her.

Charlotte felt a flush of heat covering her. It was creeping up from her abdomen, over her neck, spreading up to her face.

What did she want Clement Ambode to say he would do to her?

She knew she was fading, staring into the sky. She was acting like an idiot, but she couldn't quite reel herself back in.

"I apologize," Ambode said, turning to open the door of the running car for her. "The heat is quite uncomfortable for foreigners."

Charlotte collapsed in the cool interior of the town car and used the time that Clement walked around the vehicle to try and compose herself.

The feeling just grew inside of her all day. It twisted inside of her, while she chatted with a Yoruba woman who sold windchimes made of broken glass. They hung in her shop like beautiful knives, all drawing customers' eyes to them. The danger of looking upward into shards of broken glass was titillating, as they swung over Charlotte's head, threatening blindness if they should fall.

But it wasn't just the glass, was it? She could feel Clement's eyes on her, and they sucked up the downy hair on her back like magnet would have pulled on thin strands of steel. Her back turned to goose flesh and she covered herself with a shawl while the old woman squinted at her with a strange expression. White people usually complained about the heat.

What had Ambode done to her?

Nothing. All day he had done nothing.

He stood, arms folded together in front of him. He waited. He drove the car. He didn't even make small talk.

Why was she so obsessed with him? Why did he radiate the way he did, standing behind her? She couldn't shake the heat he was giving off. Almost like a low hum, an electromagnetic force, that breathed on her from his direction.

They had sat, facing each other, at the Yala cafe in Ikoyi. He had insisted they return to wealthy Lagos for lunch. His eyes were hidden behind his sunglasses, but Charlotte liked to imagine that they were watching her. She was sure she could feel him making smooth sweeps over her body, lingering on the shadowy dip between her breasts.

What had they talked about? They had talked about something, she was sure of it. She had watched his lips moving – his two chocolate-colored lips, stained ever-so-slightly purple, and he had been saying something about Lagos. About corruption, about the weather. Charlotte had imagined what his lips would feel like on her skin. Behind her knee. Wet on her mouth. Dry on her stomach.

She had worked herself up into such a heat that she was actually worried, as she stepped away to the restroom, that her beige pants would reveal how much she had craved him, how much molten heat had seeped out of her while she sat across from him.

In the bathroom she had wiped a cool paper towel over her neck. In the mirror her face looked strange to her. Her cheeks were pink, her lips were somehow fuller. She tipped her head forward and wiped the back of her neck.

God. Did she have fucking malaria or something? Had she overdosed on her mefloquine? She did it all the time. It gave her double vision. Andrew laughed at her because the filthy city had smoked all the mosquitoes away, but she wasn't taking any chances.

Andrew.

She tried to keep Andrew in her mind.

She was married. She loved Andrew.

She had taken too many anti-malaria pills.

She needed to go home and forget about Clement Ambode.

She repeated Andrew's name, all the way to the table. When she sat down Ambode burned through her skin, and she felt like her body was shifting underneath it, like a sea. Her stomach was cold, and her heart was racing.

"You look unwell, Mrs. Walters."

Charlotte nodded. She held a napkin to her mouth, as if it would steady her shaking voice. Was she sweating?

"I think I took too much..too many malaria pills. Have you ever done that?"

Clement Ambode's mouth turned up slightly. But he shook his head with the smile suppressed.

"I think...I need to go home early today. Just today."

Her voice was unsteady. She felt like she was floating across the room.

Clement Ambode followed Charlotte Walters, his eyes on her neck, where white hairs rose when he stood close to her.

He tried not to think about that.

Charlotte closed the door to her bedroom.

She tried to look around, to take stock of the things she *had*. She placed her eyes on the framed photos of herself and Andrew. She had Andrew. She had a good life.

She tried to imagine a different time, when she loved Andrew desperately with the kind of love that was still wet behind the ears.

She looked at her curtains, moving slightly in the breeze. She surveyed all of the matching glass and silver, marble and fabric, the fresh-cut flowers.

She tried to stuff it all inside of her mind so she could remember what she had and how she didn't want to, shouldn't think about -

The way Clement's cock would feel, growing hard against the small of her back.

What he would taste like, what the hulking weight of him would feel like, pushing her down, down into the covers, pressing her there where she couldn't move or breathe or do anything but spread her legs and let him fill her full of his virile, hot, wet seed, until she spilled all over the sheets -

Charlotte looked around desperately, as though something – some object – could help her.

She closed her eyes.

It wasn't just jungle fever. She had seen a black man before for chrissake. She saw black men every day, and she hadn't gone apeshit over every one.

Was it the heat? Was it the breezy, oily, salty air that was always heated to the temperature of skin? The sun? The lack of oxygen in the streets? Was it all of the brightly colored clothing clinging to so many black bodies?

Or was it just Clement Ambode?

His calm stare like that of a panther, his muscles moving like big strong cat, his eyes peeling away her clothing and stroking her skin to an orgasm without even touching her?

She could feel that she was wet. She was *soaking, sopping*, wet. She could smell herself. She had an ache inside of her that she hadn't felt for years. In her mind the ache wrapped itself around Clement Ambode's dark black muscles and throbbed.

Her ears were pulsing with blood.

She locked the door.

And then, almost frantically, she threw herself on the bed face-first, slid her hand into her underwear, and amid the sloppily wet liquids that were oozing out of her, she stroked her clit.

In her mind she was face-first on her bed like she was now, but her aching pussy was filled, full and brimming, and Clement Ambode was pumping her full of his cum while he held to her the sheets and took what he wanted.

She came in less than thirty seconds.

Satisfied for a moment, she sat up.

It wasn't long before it all began to creep up on her again. Like the jungle. Like a fever. She was flushed, and in fifteen minutes she was aching again. She lay on her back and absorbed her seasickness. She could not get Clement Ambode out of her mind.

Chapter 7: Things Unsaid

Andrew watched Charlotte stab at her salad.

Oh, you know, good.

He had spoken already to Clement Ambode, who had reported Charlotte's mefloquine-induced sickness to him.

She took a sip of wine.

Andrew was wondering why Charlotte had answered only:

"Oh, you know, good," when he had asked her about her day. Now he was waiting. Resisting the urge to ask her how she felt. Resisting the urge to barrage her with questions.

Why was she being secretive?

"How's the fixer?"

Was there a pause there, too long? Did her fork shake every-so-slightly where it was poised over her purple lettuce? Was she nodding too rapidly as she looked at the wall behind him, feigning a scan of her memory?

"Yeah. Uh-huh. I think he'll work out okay."

Andrew wasn't quite sure what he was doing. His eyes were moving all over her, and they were looking for something. He was peeling every little flicker of dishonesty away from her and injecting it into his bloodstream like a drug. His cock was alive, filling up slowly, using whatever it was he getting from Charlotte right now to feed it.

"What's his name again?"

A tiny bit of color flared on Charlotte's left cheek. Her eyes moved as though she were reading something on the table. His name was on her lips instantly, but she held it there. She pretended to have to think of it.

She looked skyward.

God, she was a terrible actress.

"Uh..Clement something. Ambrosia, or...you know, some African-sounding name."

As if she didn't know. As if she didn't have it in her mouth like a sweet liquid.

“Uh huh.” He couldn't stop himself. He felt like he actually couldn't. His stomach was twisting and he couldn't even identify the feeling. “And he's good then?”

“Yep. Seems so...I mean, it was only the first day.”

“Knows the city?”

Too long of a pause here? Did she pause too long, look too distantly at the wall?

She nodded. She gulped some wine. “Mmmhmmm.”

Whatever it was that was growing inside of Andrew twisted. It kicked him, it squeezed his heart. It pumped blood into his cock. His temples ached with his own fast pulse, his pounding blood.

“You feeling okay, Char?”

Eyes down, eyes to the side. More blush filling her capillaries, staining her cheek just below the cheekbone. “Yeah. Uh-huh. Why?”

She stuffed lettuce in her mouth. Was she doing it nervously?

“You just look a little...off.”

He waited, his pain coiling up inside of him, winding up tight, threatening to spring open and shred him. Time seemed to slow as he waited for Charlotte to say that she had taken too much mefloquine. That she had felt ill.

What did it mean, Andrew wondered, that she didn't mention it?

It could mean she simply forgot all about it. That she felt better. That she had actually forgotten it.

All reasonable explanations.

But as the silence dragged on, Andrew found himself preferring to think about the other possibility:

She was lying to him to hide something.

Why did he like it so much, that idea?

He took a sip of wine to stop himself from trying to drag more out of her. He didn't know what he was doing, why he was laying these traps. Why he *wanted* Charlotte to lie to him.

He was turned on. So turned on. Charlotte reached for his plate.

He placed his fingertips on her upturned wrist. He stroked her skin.

He raised his eyebrows.

Charlotte's eyes were on her wrist.

To his surprise, she pushed the plates aside. She moved quickly to his lap, crawling on top of him. Her hand moved down to his cock, and her face

only registered the slightest surprise when she found it hard as a rock.

She was looking through him, even though her eyes were on his. She was seeing something else, thinking of something else. He was sure of it.

She unbuckled his belt and tore away his clothing with an uncharacteristic aggressiveness.

Andrew felt something inside of him. Something primal, something dark. He watched Charlotte's face, stripping away her expression like pieces of flesh he wanted to eat: he loved that she was elsewhere. He loved that as her found its way into his boxers and squeezed his member, she was imagining someone else's cock.

He loved that he knew whose.

She pulled his clothes away only as much as she needed to get him free. Then she moved herself to hover over his cock. As she pushed away her underwear with her fingers, Andrew felt that it was wet. She was so incredibly wet, already.

Wet from thinking of Ambode. Thinking of his thick, black neck. His strong chest, his arms of steely muscle. Thinking about him inside of her, deeper and deeper and deeper, until she screamed.

She moved the tip of his cock to her opening, and he could feel her moisture dripping down his shaft already.

It was burning through him now, the pain, and he was pressing it into his own chest like her was eating hot coals. He couldn't stop himself. His eyes crawled all over Charlotte's face. She was looking beyond him now, and when he placed his finger on her lip, she seemed not to even know it was there.

Her pussy swallowed his cock. Her underwear rubbed against him, scratchy. It was going to rub him raw where she was riding him, up and down. Her flesh was hot, and she felt like silk she was so wet and soft.

Absently, she opened her mouth and sucked on his finger. As though she realized, suddenly it was there, and knew she had better do something about it.

And then she closed her eyes, and she rode him for herself, thinking of something else, and someone else. He felt her come in no time at all. Her muscles tensed around him and then her pussy seemed to burst, like the inside of a filled candy. But hotter. Wetter.

The smell of her hot flesh, of her honey-scented pussy, of vinegar on her lips from her salad, rose through his nostrils like a drug.

Once she had gotten what she wanted, she went limp, and her glassy eyes were as distant as they could be without her being unconscious, as Andrew grasped her hips and thrust himself inside of her.

He panted, his lips against her breasts. She absentmindedly ran her fingers through the back of his head.

Had he come while imagining her pussy full of big black cock? Had that really been what had sent him over the edge?

A trickle of sweat moved down her chest and spread out on his forehead. She was trying to move away from him now, but he held her close to him, almost forcefully. His cum was dripping out of her pussy and onto his balls.

He looked at the blue tile splashboard.

The realization came to him suddenly, and he was surprised he had never seen it so clearly. There, pressed against his wife's lovely, soft white tits, looking past the blue splashboard into the dull night sky over Lagos, he finally realized:

He wanted to watch another man fuck his wife.

He wanted to watch a big, black man to fuck his wife.

Chapter 8: Unlaid Plans

Clement found that lines helped him, when he needed to make his thoughts go in a certain direction. Looking at lines, following them. Visualizing the lines directing his thoughts where he needed them to go. Perhaps he should have been an architect.

Right now the lines he was looking at were the neat lines of the curbs in the Walters' neighborhood, modeled after American suburbs. Concrete curving around pure-black streets and walling off neatly trimmed lawns. Green, gray, black. Narrowing into the horizon. Driveways repeating, though no one drove their own car here. Square, erect houses. Line after line after line.

He was waiting for Charlotte Walters.

I need to get out and experience the nightlife here. Can you do that?

Clement Ambode found himself in a trap. The reliability trap. Andrew Walters called him every day, and Andrew Walters was sucking up every word he could get about his wife, like marrow out of a bone. He wanted Clement Ambode to watch over his wife, but he wanted something more.

It was bad business.

Charlotte Walters was bad business.

Line, line, line.

Of course he could take Charlotte Walters anywhere she wanted to go. Had she experienced the lovely Liquid Cat in Ikoyi..

Her voice had scratched at him through the phone. It went inside of him like smoke.

I need something off the island. That's what I want. I'm looking for something...more like what you would do.

A pause.

Do you ever go to nightclubs, Mr. Ambode?

Of course Clement Ambode could find anyone anything they wanted in Lagos. That was his job. That was his profession. He could even take a white peach like Charlotte off the island and have her back unbruised.

But what was it that Charlotte Walters wanted?

And what was it that Andrew Walters wanted?

And now Charlotte Walters was standing in front of the car. Playfully. She was wearing black that clung to her skin, black that curved like the curbs. Ambode gripped the steering wheel. He tried to push down whatever it was that Clement Ambode seemed to be wanting.

Clement Ambode, he reminded himself, was not his client.

It was not a plan, though later everything fell so neatly into place for him that Ambode thought perhaps he had special powers. Clairvoyance, and strategy. Or perhaps it was all just fated, as his grandmother would have believed. He could not have known what was going to happen later, and he had no idea that Dimeji Obi would be at Menthe that night. That Obi would sit down next to Charlotte Walters, Charlotte Walters with her tight black cups of cream and her blond hair shining across the entire place like a beacon to every man.

Charlotte who was getting drunk. Charlotte who had taken Clement by the hand as they made their way across the very packed dance floor. Charlotte who had been pressed against him, the slight hardness of her breasts against his lower chest, her hips against his thighs, her stomach pushed up against his cock. The music was loud, the floor was crowded – the dance floor breathed like one living being, and in the center of it was Charlotte. White, glowing Charlotte, her eyes closed, her arms up in the air, her hair sticking to her neck and her shoulders.

Now that same Charlotte, flushed and sweaty, was taking a break, and Dimeji Obi had glided in on the air like a vulture.

It took a while for Clement to put it all together. His problems – the twisting, seductive Charlotte; the hungry, paying client Andrew; his reputation; Charlotte's sweet pink pussy that he wanted to turn inside out – were all elbowing for space in his mind, and losing to the images of Charlotte's plump lips pressing themselves against the tip of his cock.

Bad for business. One skill you had to have in Ambode's line of work was a quick mind. A mind that saw everything all at once. If you saw a person you saw everything he had ever done and every hand he had ever shaken, a flow chart of his money and his connections: you saw it all. It took Ambode a few minutes of staring at Dimeji Obi, his awful afro hair, his gangster beard, for the man's connections to surface. It all had to wade

through Ambode's imaginary Charlotte, who was sucking his cock in his fertile imagination.

It took another moment to act, which was another thing that a man like Ambode needed to be able to do.

But in the time it took Ambode to get out his phone, the smooth Dimeji had poured and raised a glass of champagne. So much the better.

He wasn't sure, even at that moment, what he was going to do with the picture he snapped, so easily. He wasn't sure what he was going to do about anything.

And Clement Ambode did not like any of that. Not the slow mind, not the unleashed imagination, not the thoughts of pussy cluttering up his mind. Not Andrew Walters' cryptic desires, not Charlotte Walters' new flushed face, her eyes sparkling, her hips swaying, her sweat dripping between her breasts.

He didn't like any of it at all.

Chapter 9: Insurance

If there was one industry Clement Ambode had learned a lot about since Lagos had begun to grow drunk on European and Chinese and American money, it was the insurance industry.

Always have a lot of fucking insurance.

He sat in his apartment and surveyed the streets, the buildings, and the lights blazing on the reclamation project. The dark sand seemed to slither on the shore, and the strange machines worked tirelessly when the tide was low.

They were building a luxury island, and he was going to live on it.

Even at its very best, here, where only the ultra-rich of Nigeria and the foreigners could afford to live or even buy a coffee, Lagos still looked like Africa. And even here, in his very tall building behind very tall gates, Lagos was a dangerous place. Everyone was on the way up in Lagos, if they wanted to be – and they would all step on your face to get there. At the top of that ladder were the imperialist pig crackers, and if Lagos fell apart tomorrow, they'd let it sink right back into the ocean they were dredging it up from. The jungle would come back and grow over it, and they would all brush their hands together and move on to another city, in another dark place.

So Clement Ambode made his own insurance.

He set down his brandy – he allowed himself three, maximum, each day, and usually only for show in this country where looking every part the hardened man made business easier – and fingered the lock on his safe. His dark black fingers spun the dial playfully before they settled on the numbers of the combination – a secret no one but he had, and no one but he would ever have.

Inside the safe was all the dirt he had ever collected on anyone he had ever worked for.

As long as that ladder stayed where it was – attached to the great ivory wealth in the sky – he would keep it all locked up in this safe.

But if anyone ever tried to kick it off and take the mother ship somewhere else, he, Clement Ambode, was going to be on that helicopter out of here. There was no way he wasn't landing on his feet. Not after all he'd done to get here.

He removed the memory card from his laptop. He labeled a storage envelope carefully. Protected, so that nothing would demagnetize it. One copy here, and one copy to be delivered to his safety deposit box in the Union Bank Building.

He wrote the label carefully, in the neat, square writing he was always complimented on, should anyone see it. It was militarily uniform, and never changed – just like Clement himself. Always professional, always calm.

Never tainted by haste or pressure.

Never tempted by flesh.

Walters, Charlotte. April 1, 2015. With Dimeji Obi.

Clement placed the envelope inside the safe. He didn't entirely like what he had done. He wasn't even sure what he had done.

Insurance, he reminded himself.

It was unlikely he would ever use anything against Sidel Group. Those bastards didn't care how deep they got into the shit. They'd be the last ones out, if they ever left at all – and it would take Boko Haram overrunning the whole city for them to think about leaving.

And they always paid on time.

This was just insurance, like all his other insurance.

He gave the combination lock a spin.

He would repeat it until he believed it.

Charlotte twisted the lid off a bottle of water and gulped it.

She was in the kitchen, in the dark. The hum of the refrigerator was the only sound. The marble floor cooled the throb of her sore feet. Her dress was still damp in the back from the sweat she had worked up dancing. Something in the atmosphere gave her the feeling of being a teenager again. Sneaking in late.

Like a phantom pain, she felt Clement's heavy chest against her own. She felt him pressed against her. His eyes on her. What would it be like to give herself over to his commanding stare? To let him make her do what he wanted?

Her thoughts were getting dirtier and dirtier, too. Why was that? She no longer just thought of him ripping away her dress and lying on top of her with his cock between her legs. Now she thought of him forcing her to her knees with his steely stare, she thought of swallowing his seed, she thought of licking her own juices off the length of his shaft. She thought of giving him her last virginal gift, what it would be like to endure the pain of his cock inside of her ass, just to be possessed by him.

She let out a strange sound. All night her desires had twisted inside of her, and now she was so heated up again she ached.

She set the water down and went toward the bedroom.

The light was on in the second bedroom, the one Andrew used as an office and that he slept in when he was kept awake at night by the things that troubled him. Charlotte stood in the doorway.

Andrew often slept sitting up straight in a chair. He worked until he was exhausted, and then he closed his eyes and slept. The first few times she had found him like this he had terrified her: he looked like a corpse, as though he had been staged that way.

She turned off the light.

Her body was still sweating, and she still ached in the center of her legs.

Showerhead it was.

She knew she shouldn't do it again.

She knew she should ask for another fixer, another driver.

No. The right thing to do now, she thought, was to claim to be ill, to need a trip to Chicago, to...

She racked her mind desperately for a relative she could claim had fallen ill. Someone she needed to visit.

Everyone had already died.

Her mind was filled, like an echo chamber, with the throbbing, deep rhythm of Lagos' nightclubs. The blue lights, the dark skin everywhere, Clement Ambode pressed against her back...

"Fuck," she hissed.

The nightlife of Nigeria, she insisted to herself, was a crucial element of her research.

The clatter of a bowl in the sink broke her reverie. "What's up?" Andrew said. He peered through the window. "Trash again?"

She turned to him slowly. Even as her mouth opened, she wasn't sure what she would say. It could have been anything, up until the last second. Her mind and her feelings were flapping around like debris in a hurricane. She could have said: *I need to go back to Chicago to take a breather from this place. Find an editor. I'm afraid of Ebola. I need to go to France for a conference. I need a new fixer because I want to fuck the one I have. I want to move back to New York. I found a fertility doctor in Switzerland, maybe I'll go there this week, I can only go there this week. My uncle..my cousin..my friend from high school... James died.* All of it came to the tip of her mouth, all of it was there to be said.

But when she spoke, she said instead:

"I think I have the vein of this story now. I'm going to need to go out again. Maybe a lot."

And Andrew could have said a million things. But he blinked like a dumb animal.

"The Lagos story?"

It was a crucial moment, she would reflect later. The kind of moment she liked to dig out of the people she wrote about, because it was always there, somewhere in their past. All these people who had done such very incredible things. Bad things, great things; the brave and the cowardly and the superhuman and the subhuman. Most people never saw themselves coming. They all had a moment, though, a moment when they tipped. When, like a drop of water that could go any direction after striking a surface, they started off on one path instead of another.

Charlotte waited for Andrew to say something else. But he didn't. So she nodded, and he looked at his watch, said *shit*, and that was that.

Ten hours later she was looking at herself in the mirror, and waiting for Clement Ambode.

Chapter 10: The Unexpected

Had someone slipped something into her drink?

The music seemed to get louder without getting louder, and the lights were flashing with throbbing beat beneath the hook. Her skin was shaking, the room was full and dark and everywhere skin was pressed to skin, glistening ebony, large beautiful lips. All of it swirled and bounced and sweat, and Charlotte was inside of it, like blood in a heart. She felt young again. She leaned back on the couch and watched the dance floor, but it was as if she could see through it, all the way to Clement Ambode.

As though he were the only man in the room.

It took her a few minutes to realize that the people he had introduced her to had left, that she was sitting alone. Eyes were on her, and she looked back at them. She didn't look away, she didn't blink.

Across the room, leaning on the bar, speaking in low tones to a thin woman with an extraordinary afro, her eyes large and her red lips bright against her fair black skin. Charlotte couldn't know it but he was hearing nothing she said.

Clement was watching Charlotte.

Bad for business, Charlotte Walters. Her white skin was lit up blue by the club lights, and her eyes were on him.

Now was the time to reel her in, gently pulling, letting out slack. Supposing he wanted to, which he didn't.

Which he *shouldn't*.

Clement had a sense for danger, and he had been, at every turn, one step ahead of it. If there was thing he knew it was when to fall back, when to disappear into an alley and be gone.

Charlotte's lips looked like blood, her eyes looked like glass. She was a doll, her arms hanging down the couch. Her legs were crossed and she tapped a shoe before she lifted her leg – a long, sculpted leg, muscled from the running those American girls insisted on doing. For a moment between her legs, at the very end of the darkness between her thighs, he saw the cream-colored silk of her panties.

She was still looking at him.

He knew he was done, at that moment. He leaned over to Genevieve, his mouth tried to ask her to take him home – she wanted him Genevieve, and Genevieve was a beautiful woman, a safe woman, a dark sugary woman who he would love to eat up.

But he found his lips instead asking Genevieve to excuse him. He had business to take care of.

And then he was moving through the dancers. All the skin that touched him was Charlotte's, and she looked down at him approaching like a queen upon a servant.

“She's very beautiful,” Charlotte said. When the comment had formed in her mind, it had a snippy quality to it, and she hated herself for letting it escape her mouth. It reeked of jealousy, of weakness, and it was ridiculous to be feeling anything like that. But the woman at the bar had been so very beautiful, that when the words left Charlotte's lips, they only breathed admiration.

Clement smiled. “All women are beautiful.”

Charlotte knew it was time to go home. The music was too loud. There was too much skin, bare and sweaty, near her. Clement was looking at her with too much intensity, and her mind was thinking far too much about what his chest would feel like pressed against her back, his hands on her breasts, his cock between her thighs...

Clement was not sure himself why he did it, but once it was done, there was no way either of them were going to stop what was happening. He was a professional man, and one thing that had made him rise above all the other men in his profession was that he kept his cock well away from his business.

But the lights were gathering across Charlotte Walters' pale skin like blue butterflies around an angel. Her blond hair was draped over one side of her shoulder, her red lips looked dark and her blue eyes seemed iridescent. He had a nice view of the very top of her cream silk bra, an expensive lingerie from a boutique on Victoria Island. Her cream-colored panties flashed through his mind. In the heat she was giving off the faint smell of a rose. An English-American rose, pale pink and dewy.

He leaned forward, not believing his own body and his own mouth as they did what they did. He leaned to where his mouth was just above her

ear, as though he were looking for something over her head. His left hand moved down her arm, and grasped the drink in her hand. Her fingers popped away from it, like she was a puppet he controlled.

“Let's get out of here,” he said.

He knew she was his, but he left these words lingering in the air and turned, walking into the throngs of people. She would either follow, or she would not.

Charlotte moved, though. Like she was hypnotized. The music throbbed in her ears, and she kept her eyes on the thick neck of Clement Ambode, his muscled back. The crowd seemed to part for her, as though they knew she was being dragged as though by a magnet.

It was hot outside. Clement walked without turning around to the car. He opened the door for her.

What was she thinking? She was thinking nothing, she was thinking everything.

Clement sat down next to her. His big hand moved forward, reaching past her to the front of the car, where he pressed the lock button. The car's doors hummed lightly.

The music was muffled now. They were behind the building. The glass was impenetrably dark, but this was also Lagos: no one looked inside of cars.

They sat side by side for few moments. Charlotte's ears felt numb, as though she were underwater. Her chest was tight, and she could feel her underwear sticking to her between her legs.

There was no talk, no discussion. When he turned to her she knew from the look in his eyes that he was going to break her open like a fruit and lick up all of her that he wanted to. And she wanted him to do it. Her eyes dropped to where his erection was pressing against his impeccable suit.

The last real thought that went through her head was how he would get himself out of his suit.

His hand was already on her thigh, hot and curiously dry. Charlotte was shiny with sweat from inside the club. The heat of his hand rippled like a hot wave all the way to her pussy, which was throbbing and so wet her panties were already soaked. Clement moved the skirt up, and his smooth black hand with it, until his fingertips brushed over her damp underwear.

Without saying anything, without needing to, he commanded her with eyes and the slightest touch of his hand to spread her legs wider, and gazing

like a deer trapped in the headlights, Charlotte did. She would do whatever he wanted. She closed her eyes and purred as he worked his finger underneath the fabric of her panties, right inside of her, and then up. He stroked her clit and she jerked involuntarily.

He pulled his fingers from her body, and lifted them to just below his nose. She smelled like honey and fruit, and the feral scent of woman.

His fingers moved under her skirt again, and he stripped the panties away from her, ripping the seam in a single motion.

Charlotte, not believing even herself, spread her legs a little wider. She knew he could smell her – she could smell herself, she could imagine what her slit looked like, pink and shining with her excitement. She watched his long, sculpted black finger as it extended toward her.

Every dirty thought she could have ever had was filling her mind as his finger flicked over her swollen clit. It felt so good to want a man the way she wanted him right now: she really wanted him inside of her, she could almost feel him there already.

His other hand was popping the buttons of her blouse open, and all the while his burning stare was devouring her. He dropped his eyes only to take in a view of her breasts, before he twisted her bra and her shirt up over her hands and held her arms suspended above her in the bondage of her own clothing.

Charlotte was breathing so heavily now that she could not control her body. It swayed back and forth, exposed to him, his fingers already so close to being inside of her. She felt the expression on her face, swimming over her: she was pleading with her eyes, she was begging him to give her what she wanted. She couldn't stop herself.

He held her, trapped in her shirt, while his expert fingers tugged at the skin above her clitoris, exposing her hard little button. She could feel the air on it, and she sucked in her breath. The dark pink membrane that covered her raw flesh was too sensitive to be touched, and she squirmed in his grip, like a fish on a hook. He moved his finger over her most sensitive part, and she felt a sound leaving her lips that seemed to come from a dying animal.

She wouldn't be able to stand this torture much longer, but Clement released her hands suddenly, and dropped his dark, black head between her legs, all in one motion.

She fell back onto the seat and the door. She had abandoned all hope of being dignified. He now controlled her and she wanted it that way.

He only moved around her in a few, lazy circles, before she felt her climax erupting from deep inside of her. She grasped his head, and pushed him into her, unable to bear the excruciating pleasure. His mouth was hot, his lips were soft and large against her own intimate petals, and she shuddered into a silent, racking orgasm. She was unable to even scream, it was so intense.

As she panted, immobile, still shivering with ecstasy she had not felt in such a long time, maybe ever, he pulled her by the ankles toward him. Her head flopped onto the seat, and she felt him pushing her legs gently apart.

He unbuckled his belt slowly, his eyes all over her spread-open, wet thighs, her bare breasts, her skin silver against the black leather of the seats.

Oh the things he wanted to do to Ms. Charlotte Walters. But right now he wanted inside of her, he wanted her pink, tight flesh to close around his cock. And he wanted to fill her up until she overflowed.

Her eyes were on his cock when he took it out. He liked to see that on a woman's face. She was hypnotized by it, and he held it in his hand. He debated whether or not he could hold himself back enough to place the tip of it on her lips, and smear his precum over them like a lip gloss.

But her body, sweating and rising and falling in the moonlight, and the scent of her dripping wet cunt, nearly broke him apart as it was. He wanted to feel her.

He looked down and saw her hand clasped around the girth of his cock. She was watching it, mesmerized, pulling him toward her.

Clement looked for a moment to her face, searching for guilt, for regret. He saw none. Only hunger. The white woman's jungle fever, and it really was like a fever on her: her cheeks were flushed, her hair was sticking to her face.

He slipped himself into her engorged slit, a gush of her sweet juices spilled over, down to his balls. Her flesh was hot and her body was so pale beneath him. He found himself being overtaken by something, something he did not usually feel, something beyond just regular lust.

He went slowly, even though she begged him and coaxed him to fuck her, fuck her hard, with her open lips and her staring eyes. She pulled him by the back of the neck inside of her even deeper.

"Not yet," he breathed. He was so close to coming, and she was, too – again. She was thrusting her own hips against him like an animal, and he

wanted just a minute more of her silky cunt, her heat all around him. Her hard nipples scraped along his chest. She lifted her face to him and he felt himself wanting to suck up her red lips like candy in his mouth.

His face was contorted and he was bursting at the tip of his cock. Of course he was, he was balls-deep in all of that very wet, very pink, very hot flesh, and she was begging him to fuck all of his cum into her.

He wanted more of her, he wanted to take every part of her. He could feel his climax, though, and there was no stopping it. The briefest thought of what her ass must feel like, pink and hot, fluttered through his mind.

He lifted her up so that she was sitting on him, and she groaned and shifted her weight, howling as his cock went deeper and deeper inside of her. His cock was so large that she felt she was being torn apart; she could feel him all the way to the back of her body, at her tailbone.

They did this like it was choreographed, each one of them would think later. As though it had been done before. There was no awkwardness, no searching for each other's parts. The bad thoughts crept around in the shadows of each of their minds: Charlotte, who knew she was a cheating slut; Clement, who knew he was a bad businessman.

Neither of them wanted to be this thing. But those thoughts were pushed aside by the taste of each other's skin, the feel of their bodies, hard against soft, wet and sweaty, ink-black and silver-white.

His fingers came around to her slippery-wet anus, just as they both rose to their own agonizing climax, and she howled as she came and his fingers slid inside of her. She closed her eyes. She had no time, even, to feel the sharp pain, which turned almost instantly dull and sweet as her second orgasm came crashing down through her.

Her entire body shook, and her own creamy cum gushed from her. It slid down to lubricate Clement's rapidly thrusting cock, and he pressed against her clit as she shrieked and gasped and twitched, well past when she might have needed it. Her ass was seizing and clenching around his fingers.

He took both hands and lifted her by her hips, plunging her up and down on his cock as his own orgasm built to the breaking point, and then burst..

She was used up now, and flopped like a rag doll. He essentially jerked himself off, with her tight, pink pussy as a glove.

When he came he yelled, a thing he rarely did. There was no stopping himself, no burying the sound.

Charlotte screeched as he thrust brutally deep, deep into her. Now it almost hurt, she was too sensitive, she could take no more. Her eyes grew wet, her legs flopped uselessly. His cock was so deep inside of her she could feel nothing else.

She didn't have a single thought as he exploded inside of her, filling her up with his cum. That it was dangerous, irresponsible, insane: but she thought nothing. She just let him fill her, taking away, at last, the ache between her legs that had been building since he had taken her hand in his in front of her house.

Clement leaned against the tile of his shower, and let the water run over him.

He had returned Charlotte to Walters' house with his cum still coating the insides of her thighs, dripping out of her and into her soaked underwear. She smelled of him, and he smelled of her, and he had watched her go into the house, the two full cheeks of her ass moving like tight balls in her black skirt.

Fucking a client's wife was not reliable.

Not even in Nigeria.

Instead of hacking away at all ties to the Walters, though, and going home, taking a shower, and packing his suitcase to head for a weekend in Ghana like he should have done, he left Charlotte Walters' smell on him, ate at a kebab stand, and watched the sun come up on Lagos. The last of the clubgoers were stumbling out of the bars, and a lot of women raked their eyes over him.

All he could think about was getting inside of Charlotte Walters again, and making her scream enough that her honey-flavored cum would gush like a fountain over his balls.

He finally turned on the shower and washed the scent of Charlotte from his body. Hoping she would wash away too. Dark thoughts were brewing in Clement's mind, and he didn't like that they were. Dark thoughts and pussy, dark thoughts and a woman, dark thoughts and business – it all spelled bad news.

At home, Charlotte was also in the shower. When she came home, Andrew was face-up, his arms folded over his chest and a copy of the Economist, snoring. The light was still on. A half-full glass of whiskey was

next to the bed, on the floor, and she saw the bottle tucked away behind the comforter.

In the bathroom she leaned on the sink and looked at herself in the mirror.

Her legs ached where Clement Ambode's cock had stretched her open. She could smell him. His cum was dried to the insides of her thighs. Her hair was wet and stuck to her neck. She knew she should feel guilty, and she did.

She certainly did, she told herself.

But layered over her guilt, which she abandoned quickly when she did think of it, was a new, throbbing desire. She wanted tomorrow to come already. She wanted to sit in the back of the car while her pussy welled up with desire, while the heat he filled her with slithered through her like a snake, while she stared at the ebony back of Clement Ambode's neck. She wanted the tension to build all day long, to feel him looking at her and thinking of what he would do to her. She wanted him to think about his cock inside of her.

And then – and she only let her mind go to this place briefly – she wanted Clement Ambode's thick black cock in every single hole.

She turned on the shower, and let it wash away his cum.

Chapter 11: A Gambling Man

They said nothing to each other when he picked her up the next day. She knew what he was doing as he drove the car away from anything she might have wanted to do, and she stared at the back of his head, at his big hand on the steering wheel as he did.

She didn't try to stop him. She didn't ask where they were going.

The car stopped at a stoplight in the Financial District. Sidel's building was just a five-minute walk from here.

If she saw Andrew, she would get out.

If she saw a man wearing purple, she would get out.

But the streets were nearly empty. No one wore purple. No Andrew.

She made promises like this all the way to the underground parking lot. If she saw a dog, she would get out of the car. If he turned on the radio, it was a sign she should back out.

And all the while she prayed for signs and prayed for them not come, and her underwear grew sticky and wet, and her skin seemed to become something else, breathing on its own, rising and falling with her thoughts. Her dark thoughts. Thoughts of the vein that ran along the side of clement Ambode's cock, and how it would rub against her, inside of her, and how she would trail her tongue along it and lick up the taste of her own cum.

When he parked the car and opened the door, and the cool air beneath the ground sent a shiver over her, she still said nothing.

He said nothing.

Where had he intended to go? Was it his apartment building? Was it just any parking lot, somewhere in the heart of Victoria Island? He shut the door, and the air between them seemed to evaporate with the heat of their stares.

He moved too quickly for anything else to happen: he lifted her onto the long, low back of the car, and the metal was still hot from the sun and burned her for a moment. But the pain didn't reach her: she could only feel his big hands, smooth and dry, along the outside of her thighs.

His mouth was on hers, and his hand moved to her neck, holding her still, just where he wanted her. He didn't press against her throat, but she loved that he might have. That he could have. The weight of his hand was lighting her on fire.

He jerked away her underwear, who could say how, or where they went?

And then he was inside of her. All without saying a word.

She gasped as his girth stretched her open. He held her neck up straight and his hand closed ever so slightly, making her just dizzy enough that ecstasy buzzed throughout her body as he rammed himself into her.

She came again almost instantly – she had been so worked up by the time they got there that it took almost nothing to send her over the edge. And so she was there, suspended, curiously so much like that night with Andrew: spent, while he held her as he wanted her and fucked his cum into her wet, clenching hole.

When he came he thrust so hard inside of her she felt she might split in two, and then, like a salve, his cum spread out inside of her body. He shook with his climax, his hand tight on her throat, for a full minute, before he released her.

And still not a word between them.

They got back in the car. They were still panting lightly, blocks away, when Charlotte opened her mouth. She was looking at the same place, the same street where she had first tempted fate to make her leave the car.

"I don't know what I'm doing," she said, and the words left her mouth without her realizing what she was saying. When she heard them, she knew it was true.

Ambode stared into the red of the traffic light. His lips were pressed together.

What a fucking mess.

It was time to cut out. It was time to cut losses, find a way out of this maze.

His eyes moved to the mirror, and he was sorry later that they did. Maybe if he had kept his eyes on the street light. Maybe if he had kept his eyes of Charlotte Walters from the beginning.

She was looking right back at him, and she drove a stake through his heart.

"I can't hurt Andrew," she breathed.

He nodded.

He nodded but the thing had been set on fire. A fuse was lit, the first domino had fallen. Clement Ambode started to make his own very dark plan, at that moment.

Because he was a man of action. He knew from the way that Charlotte's body opened up for him and got hotter when he touched her flesh, that she wanted something more than she wanted not to hurt Andrew. And he was a man who believed that if you did things right, everyone could have what they wanted,

It was Lagos, after all.

Clement's father was gambling man. A lot of people though perhaps Clement was too. When they saw he was successful, and they remembered his father, they thought: easy money.

But Clement never gambled.

Luck was uncontrollable, and he liked to control things.

So he was frowning as he thought of what he wanted to do. He was frowning as he thought of Charlotte Walters' tight pussy wrapped around his cock, her hair clinging to his face, her breath squeezing from her body with each thrust of his cock.

He was frowning as he turned off the E-1 and headed back to the island. Frowning still, in the bank as the teller closed the doors behind him and he stood over his deposit box.

The envelope was on the top of the pile. His own handwriting stared at him.

Walters, Charlotte.

He sucked in his breath.

What the fuck was he doing?

He slammed the lid down and placed the box halfway back in the slot. He bit his lip, he looked at the ceiling.

Clement had never been a man to be taken down by the smell and the slippery feel of a woman on his cock.

This was a mistake.

Mistake, he thought, as he opened the box.

Andrew Walters was a gamble.

Charlotte Walters was a gamble.

But her remembered the way she had bucked against him, her back against his chest, her milky skin every around him, enclosing him...

She just needed a way to make what she was doing okay.

And he, Clement Ambode, fixer, had that way.

Clement's body was moving him along at a fast clip. A professional clip. And he could not stop it. He could not stop his legs from walking into Walters' office, or his hands from closing the door behind him, or his fingers from placing the memory card in the laptop, or his eyes from watching Walters' face as he watched the slide-show.

He could not change his face when the smirk came across his lips, when he saw that Walters, the dumb Yankee fuck, had no idea what he was looking at. He could not stop his middle finger as it froze the show on his money-maker: Charlotte's long white arm extended, a glass of wine held up to a flute of champagne, caught at the very moment that the crystal clink had echoed across the room. And holding the campaign flute touching hers, the black arm of one Dimeji Obi.

He watched Walters, whose eyes roamed all over the picture. In one way his eyes were panicked, like a scared animal. In another way, they were hungry. They were licking at a plate of crumbs and he was starving.

Ambode let all of his emotions flicker and fade across his features while he read him. He was disappointed. He had wanted something more incriminating. Something more sexual. Something more like a big, thick cock inside of his wife's spread legs.

He also did not know this about himself. Not really.

The thing that was really astonishing is that the dumb animal did not know what he was really looking at.

Ambode continued to use his middle finger, because he enjoyed the excuses he could make for himself for making lewd gestures at the people he worked for. He placed it against Obi's face, and pressed the screen until it rippled. A flicker of annoyance flashed across the white man's face.

"Do you know who that is?" Clement let his baritone voice cancel whatever Walter was about to say about the screen.

"Is she sleeping with this man?" Walters panted. He licked his lips.

Ambode thought for a moment about whether or not he wished it were so.

“This man,” he said calmly, folding his arms into his lap as though he were delivering a friendly lecture to a friend. “Is Dimeji Obi.”

He was relieved to see that the name had the effect he had desired. At the very least, he would not have to sit there explaining to Andrew Walters who Dimeji Obi was, that he was an untouchable for Sidel, that Walters' wife toasting him affectionately would like...well, something very bad. Especially here in Nigeria, where rumors and handshakes and the conversations in dark private rooms did more than contracts, to build things and to tear them down.

He saw, though, that while Walters had taken in the full implication of Obi's name, the man was still most concerned with his original question. He was looking at the screen like a child looking through a window at a coveted bike.

“Is she sleeping with him?”

Clement let the question hang in the air. Now he had him, and he had him right where he wanted him, if only the fucking idiot could come to this hunger in a few minutes.

He folded the laptop closed.

“Andrew,” he said sharply. “Man, you have got to focus on what I am showing you. This man, this man your wife is maybe fucking, maybe not,” (for he wasn't quite ready to let him know), “this man is a very dangerous man for you. Your wife cannot be seen with a man like this. Do you understand what I am telling you?”

He placed his finger on the top of the laptop, pointing down at it. He let his Nigerian accent take on its richest tones, its most frightening, wet, tropical qualities. He became as African as he could sound.

“This is a very damaging photo, Andrew. Do you see what I am telling you?”

When Andrew fell back into his chair, his eyes on Clement, his mouth open, it seemed to Clement that he had almost known this moment was coming. His mouth opened and closed, and he crawled around in his skin, but he seemed very much to Clement like a man who was used to being backed into corners.

He sort of relaxed into it.

“Are you...blackmailing me?”

Clement opened his hands so that his light-colored palms were open, as though he were showing that his magic hat was empty. See? No bunny.

“Andrew,” he cooed. “I am a businessman. I don't like words like blackmail.” He thought for a moment, and added a bit of sinister humor. “It's also a very racist word, this *blackmail*.”

Andrew looked apologetic. What a sap. Clement leaned in.

It was just like Charlotte. He had to be coaxed, had to be carefully handled until he was so ready for it that he came of his own accord.

“But listen, Andrew, I am here in a way to do you a favor. I have something you want, and you have something I want.”

Let it marinate, let it sit with him a moment.

“I know a lot about men like you, Andrew. And I think the thing we want can be...” he looked up at the ceiling, as though he were not a native speaker of English and he was searching for a word. “We can be mutually satisfied by what I want.”

Andrew was utterly speechless. He was calculating how much money he had. All white men did this when they were under the gun.

“I am talking about something other than your money,” Ambode said, uncharacteristically annoyed.

Still, Andrew didn't get it.

Sometimes you could not do foreplay. Sometimes you just needed to throw a woman against a wall.

“Let's talk about your wife,” Clement said.

Charlotte Walters. Bad as hell for business. Clement could scarcely believe the words he said to Andrew Walters as they left his mouth, but they did.

Chapter 12: I Want To Watch

Andrew closed the door behind him and looked at it, as though he had forgotten something in the car. Charlotte looked up at him.

He knew.

It was the only thing she could think of. Something was changed about Andrew, something was clouding up his mind. He looked beaten, stunned.

God. He knew.

Charlotte breathed out and tried to keep her voice from shaking.

“Something wrong?”

Don't rat yourself out before you know what's happening, she reminded herself.

She watched him shake his head.

Oh fuck, she was a bad person. She loved Andrew. She didn't want to hurt him. Not now that she could see it on his face.

“I need to talk to you,” he said.

She swallowed.

“Okay.”

Andrew looked up her, and his next words cut through her like a knife. “It's about Clement Ambode.”

Charlotte felt tears welling up in her eyes.

She was about to tell him everything, when he set a picture down in front of her. Good fuck, she thought, lowering her eyes. How had he already found a picture?

Had he been spying on her?

Her eyes moved over the picture, not finding Clement in it, and anger began to well up inside of her.

“How in the hell...what the hell is this?”

Andrew sat in the chair. No, he sank.

Something about the desperation with which he sat down made Charlotte close her mouth. She narrowed her eyes and looked back at the picture.

She couldn't even picture where it had been taken. She searched her mind.

"This man," Andrew said slowly. "Is very bad for Sidel."

"How bad?"

Andrew shook his head. It was the shake that Charlotte knew meant to ask nothing more.

Andrew had thought all the way home, asked the driver to make another pass around the neighborhood so he could think more.

"I would not ask you for what I am going to ask you for," he said, and Charlotte snapped her eyes to his face. Her attention was all upon now. Dread and fear hung in the air. He didn't finish the sentence. He didn't need to.

Unless it was absolutely necessary.

Beneath it though, Andrew knew that there was something else. It was the thing that Clement had known, the thing that Clement saw in him that he hadn't even realized about himself.

It was so wrong, he thought, to want what he wanted.

But now it was so close, so within his grasp. And Charlotte would do it. All he had to do was tell her.

Would she do it?

He looked over Charlotte's face, her neat nose, her soft full lips. Her angelic beauty. The woman he wanted to be the mother of his children.

There was no going back. No taking it back once it was said.

"I've been offered a deal," he said slowly. "to make this go away."

Charlotte's face was changing. Knowing, it almost seemed, faster than he gave her all the information.

"By Clement." Anger was rising in her cheeks, turning them pink and then crimson. Her lips pressed together, condensing, forming a straight line. She folded her arms. "So?" her voice had a knife's edge to it.

"Charlotte," Andrew said. "If you don't want to do it...then we'll make it work. I can..."

But he didn't finish the sentence. He didn't need to. They could throw everything away. He had no intention of doing that. And neither did she.

Charlotte closed her eyes. She wondered if this was a test of loyalty. And if so, who did it come from?

"Clement Ambode will get rid of this photo," he began, and then felt unable to finish. It was so preposterous, wasn't it? Like the plot of a bad

movie.

“If?”

He fingered the edge of the photo. “If you...” He could barely get the words out. “Have sex with him.”

Charlotte cocked her head to the side. She wondered what the point of this could possibly be. Her lips were trembling, the way they did when she told any kind of important lie. She bit her lower lip but she could feel her upper lip moving in small spasms.

What on earth could Clement be playing at?

Or was it Andrew who was playing her?

Charlotte took a drag of her cigarette. It was stale and a little soggy from the humidity. It tasted like shit. She had hidden the box months ago, in a zip-lock baggie under in a bush.

She had no right to be angry.

She didn't even know where to direct her anger.

The nerve. The nerve of the two of them. The fucking bastards.

She took a long drag and nearly fell over from the high it gave her. The grass in their lawn was wet. In the distance the ocean was dotted with ships. She blew smoke at them and they disappeared in a fog for a moment.

Clement Ambode. What the fuck was that asshole thinking?

She shook her head as she blew more smoke.

Andrew. What a fucking crazy bastard she was married to.

After the silence, after she pretended to be offended by Ambode's proposal, after she held her hand to her forehead in mock shock, trying to think her way out of the traps that seemed to be being laid for her, she had asked him.

“Do you want me to do it?”

Andrew had cooled to a hibernating low. He could barely move his mouth.

It was now or never. It was now or never to get what he wanted.

“If I could watch you,” he had said. The tone of his sentence seemed to indicate there was something else, but he just stared at her.

“If you could watch me?!” Charlotte had shrieked.

She had stomped out of the house, and he hadn't followed because she had held her hand up and snarled at him.

But as she stared out over the hot ocean, the hot yards and the hot lights in the distant city, she gave things some cool thought. It was one of the things she knew Andrew loved about her: she flared like a fuse, but she could be rational five minutes later.

She knew Andrew well enough to know he was serious. When she thought about him saying the words *if I could watch you* she felt as if she had swallowed a cold stone. Whether it was revulsion or excitement?

It was hard to tell.

She'd heard of this before, too. She'd heard about it from one of those rail-thin twenty-somethings who had liked to jabber in the sauna. She'd always thought it was for old men married to young wives.

She dropped the cigarette and stepped on it.

After all, she could have everything she wanted this way.

She could have what she wanted from Clement.

She could have Andrew.

She could still be faithful.

Charlotte was not a dumb woman. She could see it was all too good to be true. Ironically, it was all so like the emails that promised riches to distant royalty, half of which were probably sent from Lagos. She knew she was taking some kind of bait. She knew she was probably going to regret it.

What was it that was making her ignore these warnings, push away her common sense?

Was it the constant Lagos heat, always just hot enough to lull you into a dream? Was it that they were so far away from anything and everyone that seemed real? Was it Clement himself, possessor of animal-like qualities of domination?

Was it something else, something else that she wanted?

Charlotte's stomach twisted again.

Charlotte knew she was a bad liar, and even though she was not even sure what it was she needed to lie about, or to whom, she went to bed. She locked the door.

She needed time to think about what she was going to say to Andrew.

There had been no time in her life when she had given to her desires the way she was now.

And Charlotte found that it as like the downhill plunge of a roller coaster. Did she like it? Or did she hate it?

She felt something curling around her, and she didn't know if it was going to suffocate her or not. She was not in control.

She was listening to herself, and it seemed like another Charlotte, in another universe.

So you want to watch me.

Andrew was like a puppet in her hands now. His eyes were consumed by his pupils, his cock was hard as a rock, he was open-mouthed and she could get anything from him now.

I've thought about it.

He was frozen now. His mouth was dry and he was simply staring. What else could he do? It was all in her hands now.

What would she have thought, if she hadn't already fucked Ambode? What kind of man wants to watch his wife get fucked by another man?

She had spent all night confused by her feeling about it. Didn't he love her? Didn't he want her all to himself? Why would he want to feel that kind of pain if he did?

In the end, as dawn made the outside yard blue, she realized:

It didn't really matter.

She wanted Clement. She had already been unfaithful. Couldn't she understand what kind of strange, dark things could be inside a person's heart? She still loved Andrew. It wasn't what it was about.

And so, if this was Andrew's dark desire, it was really no different than her own.

And everything was lined up perfectly so that they could all get what they wanted.

Wasn't it?

If this is really what you want, Andrew...

Her fingertips brushed over his cock.

It really seemed to be what he wanted.

Then I'll do it.

From there, it had been very strange. Andrew had slid his hands over her body.

What will you do?

It was not a probing question. Not a question meant to set boundaries. In Andrew's eyes she could see sexual hunger.

She tossed her hair over her shoulder. Andrew's new-found desires worked like anesthesia on her guilt, if her guilt was ever real. She smiled.

Did she say, *what do you want me to do?* Or did she say, *Whatever he wants me to do?* Whatever it was, she felt pulled by invisible hands as she slid down to her knees on the floor. Her eyes challenged him as she unbuckled his belt. It was eight in the morning, and Oba would arrive any minute. Andrew was dressed for work. His hand was still on a cup of coffee he had been drinking before she came into the kitchen and told him what she had thought about all night. His fingers opened, but his hand stayed with the coffee, as if he couldn't quite believe what she was doing.

She grasped his cock in her hand, and opened her mouth.

The words she had said, whatever they were, were hanging between them, electrifying the air.

But his cock was hard and the tip was wet with precum, and it told the real story.

Charlotte swirled her tongue around the tip of her husband's cock, her eyes on his eyes. She liked the way he sucked in his breath, the way his attention could not have been broken by a bomb blast.

She placed her lips on the tip of him, tasted his salty precum. How long had it been since Andrew was this hard. This turned on? Years?

Did it matter, then, as his cock moved against the roof of her mouth, against the soft palate behind it, along her throat – did it matter that they were both thinking of Clement Ambode?

She came back up for air. “I’ll do whatever he wants me to do,” she said. She felt a ripple in Andrew's thighs, and creamy white cum welled up from the swollen red eye of his cock.

Charlotte closed her eyes, and took him inside of her.

She never did this, and she fought the urge to gag as his cock went deep into her throat.

But she was thinking of a different cock, a different color, a different size, as she moved her head up and down over her husband's shaft.

In almost no time at all, she could feel Andrew tensing, ready to come.

She pulled away, and stroked his cock, teasing him with the tip of it near her lips.

She could scarcely believe herself as she said:

“I’ll even swallow for him. If that's what he wants.”

The words seemed to bury themselves beneath his skin and push his seed out of him.

She let it fall onto her chest, smiling – though she wasn't sure with what sentiment – as his cum splashed against her skin.

Then she stood up. Andrew was looking at his cock as if in disbelief.

“Tell Clement to call me. We'll do it tomorrow at lunch time. You can get back here by then, right?”

Andrew nodded and gulped. What was he feeling, she wondered.

But she didn't even know what she was feeling, so she didn't wonder long.

“I have...I have a meeting,” she heard Andrew say. “It's...can you get him here earlier?”

Charlotte smiled. The thought traveled to her head like she had slammed a bottle of champagne. She could get him to do anything she wanted.

“Tell him to call me.”

Andrew sat staring at the wall, wondering what he had set in motion, wondering if he should try to stop it, when he heard the click of the door.

Oba.

Hastily, he zipped his pants and used his crumb-infested napkin to wipe up a splatter of cum from the floor.

Oba tisked as she entered the kitchen.

Her floor was her pride. He gave her an apologetic look, and went outside, feeling outside of his own body in the heat as he waited for his driver, who would not be there for ten minutes, sweating in a small square of shade.

Chapter 13: A Dark Business

It was a dark business.

Clement listened to Andrew Walters' voice over the phone, saying that he had convinced Charlotte to go ahead with his plan. Andrew, his voice shaking, and barely able to say the words.

There was a part of Clement that wanted to undo what he had set in motion.

He was not the kind of man to over think things. He was not the kind of man to spend too much time on what he had done, or why he had done it. You had to be intuitive in Nigeria, or you could never move fast enough to come out on top.

So Clement Ambode never got around to thinking too much about what he felt for Charlotte, and how it might have gone deeper than just filling her up. And if he did have that thought, he recoiled from it like a hot coal.

Bad, bad, bad business.

Charlotte would arrange the details with him, Andrew's voice said. And then the line was dead.

It was what he wanted from Charlotte that filled Clement's mind as he pressed the number to call her. His own voice was calm when he spoke.

“When do you want to meet with me, Charlotte?”

He knew where she would want to meet. He would have bet money on it, if any bookie would have taken it. He was as close to nervous as he ever got, as hungry as he ever let himself be, while he waited for her voice to break apart the silence.

He hoped Charlotte understood his plan. Understood what it was he was trying to give to her.

But her voice was unrevealing. “I need to go to Tin Can tomorrow,” she said.

The ports.

“That's a dangerous place,” he said into the phone. His own voice, he noted with satisfaction, was devoid of revelations as hers.

A dark business. He could feel himself slipping across the lines. The compass he used to direct himself was spinning wildly. He knew it all, but he was drunk on the smell of Charlotte, the curve of Charlotte's hip, the lips that he wanted on his cock.

Charlotte gave no answer. She knew Tin Can was dangerous. It was all dangerous.

"I'll see you at ten then," she said.

And then:

"We can do what we've agreed to after I get my interview."

Ambode felt a shiver of excitement. He liked Charlotte's new voice, as much as it made something twist inside of him. Had he made a bad gamble?

And then she was gone.

When he arrived at the Walters' house at ten he sat in his car. His head felt thick, and things seemed to move in slow motion. A racket, made by a flock of birds picking over some trash in the gutter, came through the fog in his mind slowly.

Charlotte did not come out.

He went through the motions of calling Charlotte, though he knew she wouldn't answer. He walked around the car to the sidewalk, where he stood to lock his car. He knew, or at least he thought he knew, what Charlotte wanted, and his car would be here for a while. The gate was ajar. Her note was on the door, and he watched it as he moved closer to the front door. A yellow square on the rich, thick wood.

I've changed my mind. Come in.

He put his hand on the door. *Changed my mind.* As the handle moved in his hand, he felt a cool anticipation, a fear of the unknown.

The door was unlocked, and clicked open as he turned it.

It was not a changed mind about the deal. It was a changed mind about when it would happen.

The inside of the Walters' house was black and white and gray. The standard furnishings of the corporate homes. It was still, shady, quiet. It was easy to know where to go: down the hallway, to a closed door. All master bedrooms are easy to find. All the western-styled suburban homes were the same.

Clement knew why Charlotte wanted him here. He knew that Andrew was hiding somewhere, and maybe that's why he had done what he did. It was hard to say. It was hard to know what game he was playing now, and he didn't like not knowing what he was doing.

And Charlotte.

Charlotte had changed into a black silk nightie and thigh-high leggings. The fabric was just barely see-through, so her body shone through it as it moved. Giving him just a glimpse. Just a taste. She had no underwear on, and her trimmed snatch waited for him, winking through the fabric.

She sat down on the bed.

He pressed his lips together.

"You're getting down to business," he said.

"Isn't that what this is," Charlotte quipped. She fluttered her eyes prettily. She knew she was playing with fire now. She was practically begging Clement to say something that would let Andrew know he had already fucked her.

"You know it isn't just business," he said.

It wasn't just business.

Charlotte felt something twist inside of her. She fell silent.

In the closet Andrew was sweating already. He watched his wife reach out for the buckle on Ambode's suit pants. He removed his jacket at the same time. His muscles strained against the dress shirt.

You are the one, Andrew said to himself, *who set this all in motion.*

He clenched his pants as the belt unfolded from the buckle on Ambode's pants. As the expensive fabric slid to the floor over his tree-trunk thighs. As his silk boxers slipped away in the same smooth shimmer, and his thick purple cock bounced out. Uncircumcised. Enormous.

Almost immediately, Charlotte's white fingers were clasped around his meat. White on his darkness, and moving slowly down to the base of his shaft.

Her lips were opening. Her tongue flicked out and made a circle on the tip of his member.

Andrew closed his eyes. His nose was suddenly stuffy, and his breath escaped him in a sticky whisper.

When he opened his eyes again, Ambode's black cock was sliding into his wife's throat.

She moved halfway down the enormous shaft, and then back up. She looked at it, rubbing her hand up and down its length, squeezing the creamy precum from the mushroom head, and then she opened wide again and took the whole, long cock inside of her mouth.

The sound is what Andrew couldn't bear. He couldn't close his ears to it, to the wet sucking, to the sound of his wife gagging and murmuring her love of Ambode's big, thick cock. He could close out the image of her lips sucking on his shaft, but the sticky sound of her throat spreading open and being filled could not be shut out.

His hand trembled as he reached for his own cock.

He was hard as hell.

Yes, he knew it then, he had always wanted to see this. He has always wanted to see Charlotte spread open by another man.

He just hadn't expected Charlotte to be so...willing.

Ambode tipped her back onto the bed, his long black fingers just tapping her gently. She fell like rag doll and squirmed on the bed.

He moved slowly, as though he were deciding the best way to filet her. How best to penetrate her with his cock, which now seemed to be twice the size as when they began.

Clement watched Charlotte on the bed, her black nighty crawling up her torso with her movements. His own blood was raging now. He wanted to turn Charlotte Walters inside out.

He placed his hands on her knees, but she fell open for him. Between her legs, her feathery yellow hair barely hid the swollen pink of her pussy. He placed his hand on her pelvis and let his thumb touch her clit. Her body rose to meet his touch. She was ripe and she wanted him. He could smell her same scent, but stronger now – rose and honey, cream and some overripe fruit. He plunged his thumb inside of her. She was hot, almost like she had a fever.

And wet. So wet.

Andrew watched as Clement fingered his wife, and then yanked her toward him. He flipped her over, and Charlotte arranged her own body onto her knees. She pushed her hair out of her face as she gyrated her round ass for Clement's pleasure. Between her legs she was dripping her own sticky moisture.

Andrew's eyes rested on her dull pink eyelet. The place he never went. He was watching it when Clement slide some of the wet moisture

from her cunt up to the tiny hole, and pressed his thick black thumb against the flesh there in a delicate circle.

Charlotte, far from protesting, arched her back and mewled like a kitten.

“I want to own you, Charlotte.” His thumb was still circling, and Charlotte was still howling with closed eyes. “That's what's different now.”

Andrew didn't understand this remark, but it would go unnoticed like so many other things, because his racing, blood-deprived mind could only look at the black finger as it slowly sank inside his wife's asshole.

Charlotte screamed, from deep inside of herself, but she did it through a closed mouth, so it came out as a whimper. Clement used his other hand to drag her unending wetness up to his finger. He dipped his fingers inside of her pussy, coating them in her own lubricant.

Andrew's eyes widened as his finger slipped inside of Charlotte.

Clement savored the feel of her. She was even hotter here, inside her most intimate hole. She lowered herself to the sheets. She was going to let him take her, she was saying. She would let him have her all.

The sight of her submitting sent a wave of pain through Andrew. He watched it wash over Clement: his cock jerked, his muscles stiffened. He was winning.

Andrew wondered is knew that Charlotte's ass had never been taken before.

Perhaps.

He moved a second finger inside of her, and finger-fucked for a bit while she howled into the sheets. “Just relax, Charlotte.” His voice soothed her, and she squealed until she gave up, breathing heavily on the sheets, like a broken horse. For a few moments he let her lie there like that while his two fingers fucked her asshole.

Her clenched fists told the story of her real pain, but she moaned that she wanted more.

She turned her face to the closet and looked into Andrew's eyes.

Was it pleasure on her face? What was it?

Clement guided the blunt tip of his thick cock to the opening of her pussy. With his fingers still in her ass, he pushed inside of her, and her eyes widened as he filled her up.

But they all knew it was only to get his cock wet. They all knew it as he pulled his fingers from her ass and she cried out into the sheets.

Andrew looked at the size of his cock – thick, long – it couldn't possibly fit inside of her.

She would stop him.

Wouldn't she?

But he knew that he wanted her not to. He knew that he wanted her to take it all, to let him stretch her open and fill her darkest hole with his creamy cum.

The sound that came from her mouth as the first inch of his cock tore her open was almost too awful to listen to. But somehow still dripping with sexiness. It was a sexed moan, a sultry shriek.

Clement spoke to her like one speaks to a wild animal. He rubbed her asscheek as though calming a horse. “Stay still for me, Charlotte. I want to fill you up. That's what you want to, isn't it.”

Charlotte only moaned, but it was clear she did want it. She wanted whatever gave to her.

“Just relax.”

It must have taken five full minutes for his thick purple meat to slide all the way into Charlotte. Inch by inch, as she squealed and screamed. Her feet twisted at the end of the bed, and her hands gathered the sheets into her fists. He could see a drop of blood where she bit her own lip. But she remained, submissive and prone, her ass tilted to Clement, taking his cock inside of her as far as it would go.

Andrew's own cock was so hard it was torturing him. He watched Clement Abode's big, thick cock penetrate and then withdraw from inside of Charlotte, over and over again. He could see that his wife's hole was going to be a gaping mess, that she would not be able walk if he kept at it much longer. Now the pain in his cock was spreading out all over his torso, and his mind was steps ahead, to when Clement would fill her hole with his cum. His eyes drifted to the two enormous balls slapping against Charlotte's skin. A man like that had to have so much cum to fill a woman up with.

Charlotte's mouth was open, and her closed eyes fluttered open.

“Oh fuck,” she howled. “Oh, fuck, your cock feels so good. It's so big. I can't take it all.”

Charlotte had no idea where the words were coming from. She was saying them for both of them: the man she was fucking and her husband, hiding in the shadows. The pain in her ass, almost unbearable at first, had dulled to a low, throbbing ache, and now she wanted to feel Clement come.

She liked lying on the sheets, her skin pressed to them, her ass in the air, her submission complete, while he pounded into her.

Though it surprised her, there was something she liked about the thought of Andrew watching. Maybe his pain. Maybe his permission. Maybe that it was one more secret in the room, where everyone was so close to each other, but no one knew everything there was to know.

But Clement slowed, and she felt his cock sliding out her slowly. He was sweating, and she could smell him. A different man entirely, a different kind of sweat. His chest was heaving with his deep breaths and his cock rose against the back of her ass and then fell, as he achingly slid from her.

When his cock at last pulled out her, she gasped.

Andrew watched as Clement placed his dark finger against the pink-red rim of his wife's ass, a black stretched hole now, and he swiped it around what he had done. Charlotte moaned.

He watched as Clement walked around his own bed on his knees, and lifted Charlotte by the hair to where his black, glistening, filthy cock was. He held it in his hand, and tilted it up. With his dark hand meshed in her blond hair, he lifted her head up and down, and Charlotte obediently extended her tongue, licking herself off of him.

His wife.

Not a porn star.

Andrew submerged the groan that was crawling up from his abdomen as his cock jerked with his orgasm. It was unstoppable now, as Charlotte opened her mouth and took Clement inside of him. As the big, black Nigerian grasped her head and forced his cock all the way to the back of her throat again.

Andrew tried desperately not to close his eyes, but he couldn't manage without doing so. His cum was splattering all over the closet, and his scream was stabbing him as he kept it pressed down. When he opened his eyes Clement's face was toward the ceiling, and his cock was surely pulsing inside of Charlotte's mouth. He was no longer pumping his cock. His cum – his load of white, filthy cum – was filling her throat.

He was so deep inside of her Charlotte may not have even been able to taste it.

Charlotte sat back on her heels, and the two of them sat, panting, looking at each other.

It was this particular scene, more than any other, that would burn in Andrew's mind when he thought of this first time. They were looking at each other with something far more than just the expression of two strangers who had fucked for the first time.

What was it?

Complicity?

“Wait for me outside, can you?” Charlotte said. “I still need to get to Tin Can.”

Clement was still breathing hard.

His stern face twitched, just a little, little by little, into a small, wry smile.

“Or are you not my driver any more?”

Charlotte said it amicably. Like a little joke.

Then she tossed his boxers at him, and left Andrew to watch the big man get dressed – after wiping himself off with Andrew's sheets. Andrew heard the shower.

Clement left, and Andrew stayed in the shadows of the closet.

Charlotte was in a shirt and jeans already when she came and sat on the edge of the bed. Sliding a sandal onto her foot, she looked into the closet.

“Was that what you wanted?” she said. Her voice was impossible to read. The indifference sliced through him like a knife.

She didn't wait long for his answer, perhaps sensing he was incapacitated. She blew him a kiss, and he watched her violated ass, moving with slight discomfort and encased in her tightest jeans, as she left their master bedroom and went on about her day.

Chapter 14: It's True What They Say

Clement slid the memory card, inside of a small manilla envelope, across the table.

Charlotte had her sensual mouth around a straw, and she looked down at the table, squinting slightly in the sun. Her eyes flicked back to the street, nonchalantly. As if she knew all along how he would give it back to her, as though it were a matter of course.

A cool customer, Charlotte. She was surprising him a little more every day.

She set her drink down, and collected the package by swiping it off the table and into her purse. Then she leaned on her elbows.

“So that's it.” She had an amused smile on her face. “Are you going to tell me your game, Clement Ambode?”

Clement wondered what the question really meant. He hadn't dealt with a lot of white women, but the one he'd run across were a lot easier to read than Charlotte Walters. Was her expression challenging? Or was it amused?

She was turning into a Lagonian. Dark. Secretive. Maybe a little polluted beneath the still water.

Did she know that he knew her husband Andrew was watching? Did she care? And did she know why he had created this elaborate plan?

Did he even know the answer to that last question?

He turned his dark face into the sun, as if he were looking for the answer on the roof. He smiled. It was all Charlotte's game now.

He wondered if she knew that yet.

“I'll use an expression your American corporate types seem to like so much.” He stirred his coffee, and furrowed his brow. “It's strange they like to say this. Americans like things so...cut and dry.”

Charlotte's lips made a curious shape as she looked at him.

He brought the cup to his lips.

He set it back down, and with his eyes on hers, he said:

“It is what it is. That's what they say, isn't it?”

It wasn't a question.

Charlotte knew though, as she sat back in her chair and brought the straw of her lemonade to her lips, that it was exactly that. It was what it was, and Clement Ambode had given the whole thing to her in a manila envelope, where it was sitting next to the scribbled, unfilled prescription for birth control.

It was what it was.

Whatever that was.

Charlotte squinted into the sun-bleached street. The cafe they were at looked out onto the lagoon, which appeared blue in this particular light. She could almost imagine she was somewhere different. Somewhere cleaner. Somewhere where everything people did was somehow cleaner. More “cut and dry.”

But she was in Lagos. It was humid as fuck and Clement Ambode was shining darkly in the bright light, like an ebony god.

“It true what they say, isn't it.” Her words were slow, gliding over the table like the heat and the smog, and the slow, dark pulse of the city. Clement's eyebrows raised only a fraction of a fraction of an inch. His smile lurked beneath his lips. He was waiting.

Charlotte blew a small, incredulous snort of air through her nose.

“You can make anything happen in Lagos.”

Afterword

Those who were kind enough to read this for me while it was in its inception all wanted to know: was Charlotte using Clement for her barely-referred-to dreams of motherhood? What did she do with the memory card? Did she give it to Andrew, or did she save it and let her own

game continue, for her own purposes? And what of Clement? Did she tell him what she did, or what she wanted, or what she really planned?

The first part of the book, which takes place some months later, only lets us know that Charlotte and Clement's relationship continues, in Andrew's bed, with Andrew watching.

I've been urged to tell it all, but I like leaving it at this, so that Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement can be whatever you want them to be.

Perhaps she never filled her prescription. Perhaps she never gave the envelope to Andrew, to let him know that they were released from a blackmail that was never really blackmail.

Perhaps she did give Andrew the envelope, but Andrew knew her better than even I thought, and never stopped watching her. Maybe that was something he wanted.

It's hard to say.

Lagos is a dark place.

Anything can happen there.

Thank you so much for reading and supporting independent authors. I hope you enjoyed my story as much as I enjoyed writing it. Please don't forget to leave a review...it's the best compliment I can receive!

Don't forget to [Sign Up For Our Newsletter and Get A Free Story](#)

Did you like A Dark Place? You'll love [The Hotwife Tattoo](#)

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to his wife – maybe even himself?

Try my other novella-length cuckold story, [The Hotwife Summer](#)

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

*Other Arnica Butler titles you will enjoy
(Click on the book link, or click the heading link for the newest titles in that genre):*

[INTERRACIAL CUCKOLDS](#)

[Black and White](#)

(My personal favorite quickie to write!)

Danielle' is a little prude, but married sex is stale and boring even for her. When she meets her husband's big, black boss, she can't control herself. Not only will she cheat on her husband, she lets Drake push her to the limits of her sexuality – and beyond. It's all too hot for a blurb, so look inside to get a taste of all the dirty, naughty, hard and unprotected things Danielle is going to let her husband's boss do to her.

Oh, I forgot: there's a camera in there somewhere. You won't believe what they do with the pictures.

[One Night In Puerto Rico](#)

What would you risk for it? And what could you gain, from one night to change your marriage?

When they meet and watch swingers Meg and John in action on vacation in Belize, the seeds are planted for something new in Jenny and Josh's dull marriage, and things steam up back at home in unexpected ways. But she would never really do it, would she?

Now they're on vacation one year later, and it looks like Jenny is going to

take things all the way with a big, black stud she found on the beach...but where will this lead them?

This is a 13,000-word explicit erotic story with an element of romance, and only for adults who like to imagine what could happen in just one steamy night.

First-Time Hotwife

Annie and Dave. An ordinary marriage that has gotten dull. But now Annie's made a discovery that will change their marriage completely. This story alternates between the voices of Annie and Dave as they take their marriage to the next level, and seek out a big, black stud to take Annie hard and unprotected, while her husband watches. Their marriage will never be the same...but will it be better? This story is 12,000 words and for adults only.

Cuckold Time Machine

Like any man, he's always wanted to know about his wife's ex-boyfriends, so when Mike gets his hands on a time machine, the only thing he can think of to do with it is go back in time to watch his wife with her boyfriends of the past! He starts with her big, black, athletic ex, and gets to see her take it hard and unprotected – but he's shocked by what kind of woman his wife was before he knew her! She never told him about – well, it's too dirty to write about it here, so look inside for a taste. This story is approximately 9,000 words.

Cuckold Time Machine 2

Mike is addicted to the humiliation of watching his wife with her ex-boyfriends, and he's in for a treat when he heads back in time to watch her at Spring Break. Not only is he going to see his wife taking it hard and unprotected from two big black studs, but he's going to see a whole new side of his wife when he's discovered and she decides to humiliate him by making him clean up afterward...look inside for a taste of what Mike gets to see when he travels back in time to see just how inadequate he really is!

BISEXUAL CUCKOLDS

What Ella Wanted

Nick has more than one secret desire, but he doesn't really know it until his best friend's gorgeous wife coaxes them both into showing each other their favorite porn videos. It looks like Ella wants to do more than just watch someone else getting pounded for another woman's pleasure. Is Nick brave enough to stick around and give Ella what she wants?

Approximately 15,000 words.

The Calendar

Adam's sexy MILF wife Nadia takes on a new project at her photography studio: a calendar full of hot firemen. Adam doesn't mind: he enjoys fantasizing about his wife taking it hard from her big, sexy models (especially the hot black bull). But Nadia has a whole different kind of cuckold adventure in mind. Will Adam be man enough to give her what she wants?

Approximately 11,500 words. Contains explicit scenes; for adult audiences only.

CUCKOLD HUMILIATION QUICKIES

*Need a **quickie**? These fun cuckold stories will get you hot fast:*

Legally Hotwife

Joanna's husband has always been inadequate and pathetic, but now he's dragged them both into a mess with the mob. It looks like Joanna will have to work off his debt with his new boss using her legal skills – and all of her assets! This story is approximately 11,500 words of alpha male domination and extreme cuckold humiliation, told from the female perspective and only for adults!

The Wife Swap Trick

Watching My Wife Get Jackhammered

Watching My Wife Get Lumberjacked

Watching My Wife Get Trucked

Boss Hog Cuckold

St. Paddy's Day Cucktale

Watching My Wife Get Jackhammered, Lumberjacked, and Trucked are available as one bundle for non-KU customers – only \$3.99 for all three stories:

Three Cuckold Husbands: Watching My Wife Get...

Coffee In Her Cream

Mike and Christy have a mild little swinging "game" going, but Christy is taking it a little further than Mike expected with a big, black bull named Tony. Just when Mike thinks he's already had the biggest surprise when Christy starts crossing the line, Tony's wife Michelle shows up and heats things up in a way he couldn't imagine. Find out what happens in the approximately 7,000-word, explicit, interracial wife-swapping story.

Make Yourself At Home: My Best Friend's Wife

Sam is recovering from a messy divorce and gets kicked out of the house. What can his lifetime buddy Rick do but let him stay at his place? Except Rick just got married to quite a little number: the sexy, fun, flirtatious Michelle. One night, Rick mentions that Michelle and he have a special arrangement in their marriage. Sam isn't sure what to make of things...until Michelle helps him understand.

CUCKOLD HUMILIATION ADVENTURES

Feel like an adventuresome cuckold? Long cuckold stories with original twists and a lot of humiliation for the husband:

Inside My Wife (The Series)

Lawrence wanted to know what it felt like to be his wife while he pleased her, so he tried out his new invention. But something went terribly wrong, and now he's trapped inside her body. It turns out she is quite the naughty wife... From his best friend to the big, black pool boys, he's not only forced to watch, he'll have to go along for the ride, taking it the way his wife takes it: hard and unprotected, and every nasty way she wants it. Will Lawrence find a way out, or will he be cuckolded forever, inside his wife? This 18,000-word complete series involves scenes of strange and unusual cuckold humiliation. *The complete series is available in three parts on KU, and as a bundle for \$3.99 for non-KU customers.*

Double Cucked! Cuckolded On A Container Ship

Carrie wanted a different kind of cruise...and she gets what she wants...all filled up! Her husband Dave is going to get cuckolded hard, by more than one member of this dirty, woman-starved crew. They're going to take his wife, hard and unprotected, and there's nothing he can do but watch! He thinks he's seen the worst after he watches her in some very dirty acts with some crew members, but it turns out he's been double-cucked! and she was doing it for the pleasure of the ship's captain! There's even more humiliation in store for him after that in this 14,000-word explicit cuckolding story. For adults only.

A Long, Hard Winter: Cuckolded At The Antarctic Research Station

Sam's wife Heidi is the only woman at the South Pole this winter, so it isn't long before he starts worrying about the rough, muscled, studs who are there to keep things running. It seems his wife has always wanted a

different kind of man, and now that there's nowhere else to go, she'll get her fill right here! It's bad enough when Sam watches three big, filthy roughnecks take his wife hard, doing all the dirty things she never does with him – but what will he do when Heidi has even more humiliation planned for him?

It's going to be a long, hard winter in the Antarctic!

This story is approximately 15,500 words, for adults only, and contains explicit scenes of humiliation, light femdom, reluctant cuckolding, and menage.

Hey! Did you know...Thirteenth Line author Ariel Lenov also writes cuckold stories you're sure to love! Check out:

[A Dark Wish](#)

Kurt loves hearing about his wife Melody's past exploits. He's always had a fantasy to see her with another man and when he shares his secret, he's surprised to find out it excites her too.

Agreeing to take it slow, they both want to see what happens when Melody starts flirting with Hank, the Jamaican foreman at Kurt's job.

But things speed up when they all end up at the office party and Kurt finds himself unable to put the brakes on his wife's dark wish.

This is an 11,000+ word standalone short story.

Maybe You want To Try Something Else? I love writing gender swap stories. A good introduction, if you're a fan of cuckold stories (like I think you are) is [Inside My Wife](#), a combination of gender-swap and cuckold that is sure to delight you! After that...have fun!

GENDER SWAP STORIES

[Between The Sheikh And A Hard Place 1: Turned](#)

[Between The Sheikh And A Hard Place 2: Tricked](#)

[Between The Sheikh And A Hard Place 3: Trapped](#)

Between The Sheikh And A Hard Place: Complete (\$3.99).

The Dirty Pool Series

Every Blue Moon

Turned Into A Cherry And Popped!

Turned Into A Cherry And Disciplined!

Check my [Author Page](#) for additional titles! And please don't forget to leave a review: it's the greatest compliment an indie author can receive!

Thank you!